The Stardust Engine

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Book 1: CPI & Electric Color (1986–1989)

Chapter 1: Progress Street & The Forger's Call (1986)

Progress Street, 'Ignition,' & The Apex Signing (1986–1989)

Date: 1986-10-18 at 21:30 America/New_York

October 18, 1986 — Aunt Clara's House & The Garage on Progress Street

The unheated two-car cinder-block garage behind **Aunt Clara Wright's** 1900s wood-frame farmhouse on **Progress Street NE** smelled of damp autumn oak leaves, warm vacuum tubes, and burnt coffee, and twenty-two-year-old **Ryan O'Connell** wouldn't have traded it for the finest recording studio on earth.

When Ryan, his younger sister **Cassidy**, and their identical twin maternal cousins **Evan** and **Tyler Wright** had all enrolled together as incoming freshmen in **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute's Class of '89** the previous autumn—with sixteen-year-old youngest sister **Holly O'Connell** dual-enrolled at Blacksburg High School in the mornings and taking undergraduate business and contract law classes at CPI in the afternoons—none of them had wanted to be split up across separate freshman dormitories on campus.

Fortunately, Evan and Tyler's mother—**Aunt Clara Wright**, maternal aunt to Ryan, Cassidy, and Holly—owned the two-story farmhouse on Progress Street two blocks north of **Commonwealth Mall**. By serving as their **live-in landlord** and signing a formal **`$1.00`-a-year family lease** that fifteen-year-old Holly had typed up at the kitchen table in August 1985, Aunt Clara had allowed all five of them to legitimately check the *"Residing Locally with an Immediate Adult Relative"* exemption on CPI's housing affidavit—bypassing the mandatory Freshman Dormitory Requirement so the entire family unit could live under one roof while rehearsing in the detached cinder-block garage out back.

Across the cracked concrete floor, his younger sister **Cassidy** stood behind a two-tier aluminum keyboard stand in an oversized maroon **`CPI`** sweatshirt, her fingers flying across an eight-voice analog polysynth while their identical twin maternal cousins, **Evan** and **Tyler Wright**, locked into a driving 138-BPM rhythm section that rattled the frosted glass panes of the overhead garage door.

Two weeks earlier, the four of them had entered the **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute** student union cassette contest with a blistering three-minute stadium rock anthem they had tracked on a borrowed four-track reel-to-reel machine: **"Ignition"**. They had recorded it simply hoping to win fifty dollars in campus bookstore credit and maybe hear their tape played over the PA system inside **The Crucible** before Saturday afternoon kickoff.

Instead, that afternoon, a courier envelope from Los Angeles had landed on their front porch on Progress Street.

Someone in the A&R department at **Apex Records** had heard a dubbed copy of the CPI student contest cassette. They wanted to fly out to Blacksburg to sign the band.

“Wait—play that bridge chord again, Cass,” Ryan said, stepping away from his dual-stack tube amplifier with his cherry-sunburst solid-body electric guitar slung over his shoulder. “The F-sharp minor into the D major lift. Right where the booster stage separates.”

Cassidy adjusted her round wire-rimmed glasses, her face glowing in the amber LEDs of her synthesizer rack, and pressed the sustain pedal. A lush, brassy wave of sawtooth harmonics filled the tiny Blacksburg garage, sounding less like a college rehearsal space and more like the view out the viewport of an orbital command module two hundred miles above the Blue Ridge Mountains.

“Listen to how the guitar overtones lock right into the synth filter when you hold the fifth,” Cassidy whispered, her eyes wide with the pure, unfiltered joy of discovery. “Ry, what are we going to call this one?”

Ryan looked down at the yellow spiral notebook resting on top of his amplifier, where he and Cassidy had been sketching lyrics between their Tuesday/Thursday engineering and astronomy lectures on **Commonwealth Green**.

“We wrote it about the two things the four of us have been obsessed with since we were kids,” Ryan said quietly. “The wonder of the cosmos—and the rockets it takes to get you there. Let’s call it **‘The Stardust Engine’**.”

Behind the drum kit, Tyler spun a hickory stick between his knuckles and grinned at his twin brother Evan. “Forget just calling the song that, Ry. That’s the name of the band.”

November 1986 — Sixteen-Year-Old Holly’s `$1.00` Cross-License

Before the A&R representatives from **Apex Records** ever stepped foot in Montgomery County, sixteen-year-old **Holly O’Connell**—the youngest of the three O’Connell siblings, who had skipped a grade in high school and spent her evenings reading contract law treatises at the **Pendleton Library** while her brother, sister, and cousins rehearsed—sat all five of them down at the scratched formica kitchen table on Progress Street.

“Read Clause 14 of Apex’s standard recording agreement,” Holly said, tapping a yellow highlighter against the boilerplate legal packet the label had sent ahead by overnight mail. “They call it a *Controlled Composition & Work-for-Hire Assignment*. If you sign their contract as individuals, Apex owns your band name, your songwriting masters, and your arrangements forever, while charging every penny of studio time, travel, and promotion back against your royalties as recoupable debt.”

“Can we ask them to strike Clause 14?” Evan asked, frowning over his mug of tea.

“They’re a major label in Los Angeles; they’ll never strike it if we ask,” Holly replied calmly, pulling a three-page document she had typed on an electric typewriter at the Montgomery County Courthouse law library out of her backpack. “We don’t ask them. Tonight—forty-eight hours before Apex’s lawyers arrive—you four are executing a Virginia general partnership agreement and a **Perpetual Mutual Cross-License** with me as your business manager, for one dollar of consideration.”

She slid a crisp **`$1.00`** bill across the formica table.

“Under this prior instrument,” Holly explained, her voice steady beyond her sixteen years, “every composition, arrangement, and trademark created by Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler is irrevocably vested in our family partnership first, with an automatic reversion trigger if any third-party licensee ever commits a material breach of fiduciary duty or personal safety. When Apex signs you on Thursday, they can only take an interest subject to our prior recorded cross-license.”

Ryan looked at his sixteen-year-old little sister, then exchanged a glance with Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler. Without hesitation, all four of them picked up their pens, signed the family partnership deed, and taped the `$1.00` bill inside the front cover of Holly’s ledger.

1987–1989 — *Electric Color*, *Neon Hearts*, & The Apex Gimmick

When ***Electric Color*** was released in the spring of **1987**, followed by their sophomore album ***Neon Hearts*** in **1989** right as Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler graduated from CPI, the songs they had written in the Progress Street garage—**“My Anchor Holds”**, **“Saturday Night Lights”**, and **“The Stardust Engine”**—exploded across college and rock radio.

Yet behind the scenes, a five-year cold war had already begun between the Progress Street house and Apex’s marketing tower in Los Angeles.

Apex’s executives didn’t care about orbital mechanics, analog synthesizers, or the quiet sanctuary of the Blue Ridge Mountains. Looking for a cheap 1980s MTV marketing hook, Apex’s publicity department twisted the band’s name into a tacky corporate persona gimmick—printing promotional posters that branded Cassidy as their ***“Stardust”*** and Ryan as their ***“Engine”***, while pressuring them during the 1989 *Neon Hearts* sessions to record manufactured, slickly produced pop heartbreak ballads like **“If You Walked Away”**.

Every single member of the family hated the gimmick. To Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and Holly, *“Stardust”* and *“Engine”* were never nicknames for two people—they were the cosmos and the rockets that carried all five of them together. Whenever a tour leg ended, they ignored Apex’s invitations to relocate to California and drove straight back to their rented wood-frame house on **Progress Street** in Blacksburg, where the neighbors waved from their front porches and nobody cared whether their faces were on a magazine cover.

Book 2: Live in Chicago & Mile Marker 98 (1990)

Chapter 1: Mile Marker 98 (December 10, 1990)

Mile Marker 98 & Protocol T-10 (1990)

Date: 1990-12-10 at 23:42 America/New_York

October 12 – December 10, 1990 — From *Live in Chicago* to Mile Marker 98

On the night of **October 12, 1990**, standing at the front edge of the sold-out stage in Chicago while eighteen thousand fans roared back the chorus of **"Ignition"** for the live concert recording of ***Live in Chicago***, twenty-three-year-old **Ryan O'Connell** felt invincible.

Fifty-nine days later, on the freezing night of **December 10, 1990**, that invincibility ended in three seconds of black ice and tearing steel at **Mile Marker 98**.

Apex Records' tour accounting department had refused to pay for the veteran winter mountain driver Holly had requested for the final December leg home to Virginia, hiring a cut-rate charter contractor instead. At `11:42 PM`, as snow blinded the windshield on the dark highway grade, the exhausted charter driver slammed the airbrakes on a sheet of black ice.

Sitting awake in the front lounge of the coach with his acoustic guitar across his knees while Cassidy slept in the bunk behind him, Ryan saw the guardrail rushing toward the glass. He threw himself across the aisle to brace the bunk bulkhead door so Cassidy wouldn't be thrown into the forward stairwell when the coach rolled.

He heard the screech of the tires, the violent crunch of the steel frame, and a white-hot snap in the middle of his spine—and then the world went silent beneath the falling snow.

Winter 1991 — Star City General & Protocol T-10

When Ryan woke up under the fluorescent lights of the surgical intensive care unit at **Star City General Hospital**, the orthopedic trauma surgeon didn't sugarcoat the MRI scans: a complete **T10 thoracic spinal cord injury**. Everything above his navel—his arms, his hands, his fretboard calluses, his lungs, his voice—was 100% intact. Below his tenth thoracic vertebra, he would never walk again.

For forty-eight hours, lying flat on his back listening to the rhythmic hiss of the hospital monitors, Ryan stared at the acoustic guitar case leaning against the corner wall and wondered if **The Stardust Engine** was over.

His family didn't let that thought survive past the third morning.

At `08:00 AM` on his fourth day in the step-down ward, **Cassidy**, twenty-year-old **Holly** (now in her first year of law school), and twenty-three-year-old twins **Evan** and **Tyler** walked into his hospital room carrying a portable four-track cassette deck, a pair of studio headphones, a carpenter's tape measure, and a thick three-ring binder labeled **`PROTOCOL T-10`**.

"Don't even think about saying it, Ry," Cassidy said fiercely, sitting on the edge of his hospital mattress and wrapping her arms around his shoulders so tightly he could feel her heartbeat against his collarbone. "Your hands are right here. Your voice is right here. You are my brother, and we don't play a single note without you."

Beside the bed, Evan and Tyler held up the carpenter's tape measure.

"We already measured every doorway in the Progress Street house," Evan said, his voice steady and matter-of-fact. "Thirty-six inches clear from the front porch through the kitchen, the hallway, and the bathroom. Ty and I spent all day yesterday building a twelve-foot pressure-treated timber wheelchair ramp over the front steps on Progress Street at a 1:12 grade, and we lowered your workbench and amp heads in the garage so every knob sits at forty-two inches off the floor."

"And as soon as you're cleared for outpatient rehab," Tyler added, tapping a commercial driver's manual tucked under his arm, "Evan, Holly, and I are all testing for our **Class A Commercial Driver's Licenses** with Passenger and Airbrake endorsements. Never again does an outside charter driver hired by a record label sit behind the wheel of a vehicle carrying our family."

When Ryan was discharged from Star City General in his first ultralight manual wheelchair that spring and rolled up the wooden ramp onto the porch on **Progress Street** in Blacksburg, he learned everything from the ground up: fifteen-minute weight-shift pressure reliefs, transferring from his chair to the studio bench, and reverse-climbing steep curb cuts so his front casters wouldn't catch.

In Blacksburg, surrounded by his sisters, his cousins, and Montgomery County neighbors who treated him like the exact same CPI kid who had lived on the block since 1985, Ryan healed.

Twelve hundred miles to the west, however, **Apex Records** was waiting for the third album owed under their contract—and the executives in Los Angeles had no intention of letting the band stay in Virginia.

Book 3: The Friction Catastrophe & The Warehouse Tapes (1992–1995)

Chapter 1: The Cage & The Warehouse Tapes (1992–1995)

The Beverly Hills Mansion Trap, The Friction Catastrophe & The Warehouse Tapes (1992–1995)

Date: 1992-10-14 at 08:15 America/Los_Angeles

September – October 1992 — The Recoupable Golden Cage in Beverly Hills

If anyone watching MTV in the autumn of **1992** had driven past the tall wrought-iron security gates off Coldwater Canyon in **Beverly Hills, California**, they would have assumed **The Stardust Engine** was living the ultimate rock-and-roll fantasy.

To force the band out of Blacksburg to record and promote their third studio album, ***Friction***, **Apex Records** had leased a sprawling, gated Mediterranean villa in the Beverly Hills hills—and every single member of the O'Connell and Wright family **despised** it with every fiber of their being.

First, there was the financial fraud disguised as luxury. As twenty-two-year-old **Holly O'Connell** pointed out the moment she audited Apex's monthly accounting statement at the dining room table, the label wasn't paying for the mansion out of generosity. Under standard major-label accounting, 100% of the **`$25,000-a-month` Beverly Hills lease**, the security gate guards, and the daily catering trays were being charged directly back to the band as a **recoupable advance expense**—designed to trap the five of them in perpetual unrecouped debt to Apex while keeping them isolated two thousand miles away from their Virginia support system.

Second—and far worse—was the physical reality of the house itself.

The newly hired Apex executive overseeing the project, **Julian Vance**, hadn't even bothered to read the medical file from Ryan's December 1990 highway crash at Mile Marker 98 before ordering the travel department to lease the Beverly Hills compound. The gated mansion was a monument to hostile, inaccessible excess: * **Twenty slick travertine marble steps** curved up from the circular cobblestone driveway to the heavy carved front doors, with **zero wheelchair ramps** anywhere on the property. * Inside, the ground floor was broken up by sunken conversation pits bordered by sharp brass steps, narrow antique doorways that scraped the push-rims of Ryan's manual wheelchair, and a sweeping spiral staircase leading to all five upstairs bedrooms. * Every single morning and evening for six straight weeks, **Evan** and **Tyler Wright** had to grip the frame of Ryan's manual wheelchair and haul their cousin up and down the twenty marble steps by hand while Ryan held onto the side rails, his jaw clenched against the indignity of a house that treated his chair like an intrusion. * Refusing to sleep upstairs while Ryan was stranded on the first floor,

Cassidy, Holly, Evan, and Tyler dragged the mattresses down the spiral staircase on their very first night in California and camped together on the floor of the formal dining room beside Ryan's chair.

Outside the wrought-iron gates, the air tasted like hot asphalt and eight lanes of 405 Freeway exhaust. Whenever they tried to roll down to a corner market for groceries, tabloid photographers jumped out from behind the manicured hedges shoving flashbulbs in their faces, and every label executive who stopped by the house spoke in fake, syrupy industry platitudes.

Sitting on the cold marble terrace on the evening of **October 13, 1992**, looking out over the smoggy orange haze of the Los Angeles basin while Cassidy practiced the melancholy chord progression of **"Atmosphere"** on a portable keyboard inside, Ryan rested his chin on his hand and felt a homesickness so sharp it ached in his chest.

"I hate this place, Cass," Ryan said quietly when his sister stepped out onto the terrace with two mugs of hot tea. "The marble echoes every time my tires turn. You can't see a single star through the smog. It's not the Blue Ridge. It's not **Progress Street**. It's not home."

"One more day, Ry," Cassidy promised softly, leaning down to rest her cheek against the top of his head. "Tomorrow morning is the album cover photo shoot at the downtown warehouse. As soon as it's over, we pack our bags, we hand the keys to the gate guard, and we go home to Blacksburg."

October 14, 1992 (`09:30 AM`) — The *Friction* Catastrophe (`"SHE'S MY SISTER!"`)

At `09:30 AM` the next morning, shivering inside an unheated Los Angeles warehouse studio while a rolling television cart played cartoons in the corner to pass the time, the five of them waited for **Julian Vance** to arrive.

When Vance had first pitched the album title ***Friction*** over the telephone in August, Ryan and Cassidy had believed Apex was finally letting them make a hard science-fiction concept record about the thermal atmospheric re-entry of a spacecraft hull. Cassidy had even hand-painted a concept cover showing a shuttle wreathed in plasma fire re-entering Earth's atmosphere.

They had no idea that Vance—desperate to compete with the explicit shock-value pop campaigns dominating the 1992 charts—had looked at a 1989 *Neon Hearts* promotional photo of Ryan and Cassidy, assumed the two attractive co-leads were a romantic couple rather than brother and sister, and hadn't even known Ryan was paralyzed.

When Julian Vance strode onto the warehouse floor at `10:15 AM`, took one disgusted look at Ryan's manual wheelchair, and tossed Cassidy's spacecraft painting onto a folding table as *"childish,"* the temperature in the room dropped twenty degrees.

Refusing to abandon his fabricated shock campaign, Vance turned to commercial photographer **Kevin Mitchell**, crossed out the word *SIMULATED* on the storyboard sheet, and ordered Ryan and Cassidy to set up for **"Shot 12"**—demanding that the two of them perform an explicit, sexualized pose together on the studio floor.

For two seconds, the silence in the warehouse was absolute.

Cassidy went dead white, her hands trembling so violently she nearly dropped her folder of sheet music.

Inside Ryan's chest, five years of Apex's corporate manipulation, six weeks of being trapped in a wheelchair-hostile Beverly Hills mansion, and the sheer revulsion of what Vance had just demanded of his little sister detonated all at once. Gripping his push-rims with white knuckles, Ryan roared across the concrete warehouse floor at the top of his lungs—a sound so raw and terrifying that photographer Kevin Mitchell dropped his primary camera lens onto the concrete, shattering the glass into a hundred pieces:

"SHE'S MY SISTER!"

Mitchell grabbed his camera bag, left his lighting umbrellas standing on the floor, and fled straight to his car—waiting down the block only long enough to make sure the family got out safely before driving to the Hollywood Police Precinct to give a sworn statement to detectives.

Inside the warehouse, twenty-two-year-old **Holly O'Connell** didn't yell. She snapped open her leather briefcase, pulled out a certified copy of the **November 1986 `$1.00` Perpetual Mutual Cross-License**, and slapped it into Julian Vance's chest.

"Under Paragraph 4 of our prior recorded 1986 Virginia partnership cross-license," Holly said, her voice colder than January ice on the New River, "Apex Records' material breach and unlawful coercion immediately terminates your license to the name **The Stardust Engine** and every composition we have ever written. This session is over. This album is dead. And by five o'clock tomorrow afternoon, the Superior Court of California will have a temporary restraining order sealing every reel of tape in this building."

October 15, 1992 – 1995 — Returning Home to Progress Street & *The Warehouse Tapes*

They didn't spend one more night in the Beverly Hills mansion.

Within two hours of rolling out of the downtown Los Angeles warehouse, Ryan, Cassidy, Holly, Evan, and Tyler drove back up Coldwater Canyon, packed their suitcases and instruments out of the ground-floor dining room, left the mansion keys on the marble foyer table, and headed straight east toward Interstate 40 and Interstate 81—not stopping until the green highway sign for **Blacksburg / Christiansburg** rose against the autumn ridges of the Blue Ridge Mountains and they rolled up the wooden ramp of **Aunt Clara's** farmhouse on **Progress Street NE**.

When photographer Kevin Mitchell's sworn deposition (*Evidence #94-C*) forced Apex Records into a total courtroom surrender—voiding the recording contract, surrendering 100% of the band's master tapes, and paying punitive settlement damages just to keep Mitchell off the witness stand—the family didn't look at real estate in Los Angeles, New York, or Nashville.

Instead, Holly used their settlement check to found **Engine Room Records, LLC** right there in Blacksburg (before purchasing the Progress Street property outright from Aunt Clara in 1996 to gut-renovate the farmhouse with a three-stop hydraulic elevator and custom wraparound porch ramp).

While the major-label industry blacklisted them across commercial radio from 1993 to 1995, the five of them rented an industrial cinder-block warehouse on the edge of town for full-stage rehearsals and dubbed thousands of underground cassettes by hand—**The Warehouse Tapes**—passing them from dorm room to dorm room across CPI until every student in Blacksburg knew that **The Stardust Engine** had come home for good.

Book 4: Ad Astra, Hard Reset & The Stadium Years (1996–2005)

Chapter 1: Escape Velocity (Ad Astra) & Main Engine Cutoff (1995–1997)

Main Engine Cutoff & The Magnum Opus

Date: 1995-11-14 at 12:00 America/New_York

12:00 PM — Pulling the Plug (Main Engine Cutoff)

The kerosene space heater in the corner of the rented Blacksburg warehouse clicked and rattled against the November chill, barely keeping the concrete floor above fifty degrees, yet **Ryan O'Connell** had sweat beading along his collarbone beneath his flannel shirt.

Across the room, behind a fortress of analog synthesizers wired into a secondhand twenty-four-track tape console they had bought at auction with the last of their college savings, **Cassidy** stood with her eyes closed and her headphones pressed tight over her ears. For four months, ever since the dust of the 1992 *Friction* trial and three years of corporate blacklist orders had settled over their lives, she had been pouring every nightmare of the courtroom cage—and every dream of what waited above the atmosphere—into twenty-two pages of handwritten staff paper.

At the top of the score, in thick black marker, she had written the title: **"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"**—though around the dinner table on Progress Street, the four of them already simply called it ***"Ad Astra"***.

"Six minutes and twenty seconds," **Evan** murmured over the talkback line, his fingers flying across the neck of his bass as **Tyler** drove the double-time snare climb of *Part II: Ignition* toward its peak. "Ten seconds to the cutoff, Ry."

Ryan shifted his hips fifteen degrees in his manual wheelchair—his automatic fifteen-minute pressure check—and locked his left elbow against his ribs as he drove his sunburst electric guitar up to the twentieth fret. The dual-stack tube

amplifiers behind his chair were roaring so hot that he could smell the warm dust baking off the vacuum tubes, the overdriven guitar and Cassidy's brassy sawtooth synthesizers climbing together at `11.2 kilometers per second`—the exact velocity required to tear a vessel free of Earth's gravitational well.

During rehearsal the night before, they had tried muting the strings with their palms at the end of *Part II* to transition into the weightless silence of *Part III: The Cosmos*. It had sounded too polite. A rocket stage didn't politely fade out when its fuel tanks burned dry at the edge of space; it cut off with a violent, mechanical snap that threw the astronauts forward against their harnesses in sudden zero gravity.

Ryan glanced down at the heavy black rubber power cord running from his amplifier head to the brass floor outlet beside his right caster wheel.

Five seconds.

Cassidy's voice soared to the top of her register over the pounding drums:

> *"I'm climbing! Climbing! Past the point of no return! I'm flying! Flying! With the fire I let burn! Just a signal, a distant light! Burning through the endless night! Ad astra! (To the stars!) Ad astra! Into the silent, endless night!"*

On the final downbeat of *"night!"*, Ryan didn't touch his volume knob. Still holding the screaming high note on the neck of his electric guitar with his left hand, he leaned down over his right wheel, wrapped his right fist around the thick rubber AC plug of his amplifier, and yanked it straight out of the wall socket.

POP—KZZZZT—

Silence slammed into the warehouse like a physical wall.

The red pilot light on the amplifier head died instantly, leaving only the faint, ghostly hum of Evan's fretless bass harmonics and the shimmering, weightless arpeggio of Cassidy's vintage eight-voice analog polysynth floating in the sudden vacuum of *Part III: The Cosmos*.

Across the room, Cassidy opened her eyes behind the glass of her synth rack. A slow, radiant grin broke across her face—the first unguarded smile Ryan had seen on his sister's face since the morning the federal judge had banged the gavel in 1992. She didn't stop playing. Her fingers glided across the keys as her voice rose again, clear and unburdened in the zero-gravity hush:

> *"I see the colors of the nebula A place I've only seen in dreams The reds, the blues, the purples call Flowing in majestic streams… This is the place I was meant to be! This is the Stardust that is me! The cosmos and the rocket's fire! My one, my only true desire! Loved by the sun!"*

Sitting in his chair with the warm brass prongs of the unplugged power cord resting in his lap, Ryan let out a long, quiet breath and looked over at Holly standing in the control-room doorway with her yellow legal pad tucked under her arm. They didn't have a major label anymore. They didn't have commercial radio promotion or tour buses or a million-dollar marketing budget—only a drafty warehouse, a secondhand tape machine, and the five of them.

They didn’t need any of it. Listening to Cassidy’s voice echo off the cinder-block walls of the warehouse, Ryan knew that one day—whether it took two years or twenty—they were going to play *Ad Astra* under the open stars inside **The Crucible**, and sixty-five thousand people were going to hear his sister fly.

Chapter 2: Writing Before the Distance on Progress Street (2004)

Two Blocks from Commonwealth Mall

Date: 2004-06-14 at 16:30 America/New_York

4:30 PM — Two Blocks Down the Sidewalk

Summer rain drummed steadily against the porch roof on **Progress Street NE**, washing the yellow oak pollen down the gutter toward **Commonwealth Mall** two blocks away.

At the kitchen table, **Ryan O’Connell** sat in his manual wheelchair with an unplugged single-coil electric guitar resting across his lap and a lined yellow notebook open beside his coffee mug. Across the table, **Cassidy** had her round reading glasses perched on the bridge of her nose, arranging five index cards in a row between her analog synthesizer chord charts and a printed booklet proof from **Ocean View Archives**.

For the past year—right after finishing Ryan’s sci-fi concept album **Mile Marker 98**—the four of them had been recording their 2004 hometown tribute album, **Progress Street**. Most of the record was a love letter to Blacksburg and **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute (CPI)**: the fourth-quarter roar of **“Saturday Night Lights: The Crucible”**, the cinder-block garage memories of **“Progress Street: Where the Fire Began”**, and the warm porch-light sign-off of **“Last Bus Home: Lights Out on Progress Street”**.

tucked right into the heart of the album, however, was a story that Ryan and Cassidy had been carrying in pieces since 1986.

“Look at the five-song sequence now,” Cassidy said softly, tapping the index cards in chronological order across the oak table:

1. **“Seconds Into Forever”** (*Progress Street*, Track 3)
2. **“Thunder in the Rain”** (*Progress Street*, Track 4)
3. **“Before the Distance”** (*Progress Street*, Track 8)
4. **“Sanctuary in the Storm”** (1986 vault master, slated for **Lost Sounds**)
5. **“Not Her”** (1986 vault master, slated for **Lost Sounds**)

Back in 1986, when they were undergrads at CPI, Ryan and Cassidy had written *“Sanctuary in the Storm”* and *“Not Her”* about a pair of fictional fraternal twins at CPI—**John and Erin**—who both used power wheelchairs to climb the steep **Ironstone** hills between the **Commonwealth Green**, **Faraday Hall**, and **Kincaid**

Hall. When Apex Records had rejected both duets in 1987 because the label executives refused to let a brother and sister sing heavy, protective rock songs about surviving a manipulative partner, the masters had gone into Holly's vault.

Now, fourteen years after the December 10, 1990 crash on Interstate 81 at Mile Marker 98 had put Ryan into a wheelchair of his own, he understood John and Erin's world on campus down to the millimeter.

He knew what it felt like to watch the five o'clock **Blue Ridge Transit** articulated buses line up bumper-to-bumper in the rain beneath the vaulted stone arch of **The Keystone Bridge** along **Commonwealth Mall**. He knew how a manipulative partner like **Valerie**—whom John meets when a student organizer at a Kincaid Hall speed-dating mixer accidentally skips from Track 3 (*"Seconds Into Forever"*) to Track 4 (*"Thunder in the Rain"*)—could slowly isolate someone in a wheelchair by controlling their schedule, their phone, and their transportation.

And he knew what it meant to have a twin sister who refused to let the steel bus doors close on her brother.

Ryan looked down at his yellow legal pad, where he and Cassidy had written out the chorus of **"Before the Distance"**:

> *"When the steel doors close and the platform clears You can hear the truth grinding in the gears Heed the warning hiding in his eyes Before the distance leaves your soul behind Trust the silence when he calls your name 'Cause once it's gone, nothing stays the same"*

"In the booklet novella," Ryan said, tracing the chord changes on the neck of his guitar, "when Valerie tries to force John up the front wheelchair ramp of the southbound Route 1 bus at Commonwealth Mall to isolate him for the weekend, Erin doesn't just stand under The Keystone Bridge and watch him leave. She drives her power chair straight out into the rain, locks her brakes across the bottom of the aluminum bus ramp to block it, and tells him: *'Don't get on that bus, John. Come home with me instead. Progress Street is two blocks away."*"

Across the table, Cassidy's eyes shone behind her glasses.

"And when Valerie tries to grab John's sleeve," Cassidy added, reading from her draft of Chapter 3, "Erin angles her frame at forty-five degrees to lock a physical perimeter on the sidewalk until the bus doors close without him, and they roll the two blocks down the sidewalk together to their apartment on Progress Street NE."

"And then in Chapter 4 the next spring," Ryan grinned, tapping the card for **"Not Her"**, "when that slick senior from the business school tries to box Erin's chair into the alcove outside Kincaid Hall Auditorium with his boot on the ramp, John recognizes the exact same script Valerie used on him, shifts his power chair into high gear, and puts two hundred and fifty pounds of steel between the guy and his sister."

> *"I know your game, I know your kind The little traps you leave behind You think she's weak, a fragile prey But you're not taking her away I've walked through fire, I've paid the cost And I won't let another light be lost Not her. Not today."*

Evan and **Tyler** walked into the kitchen from the back studio hallway, shaking the June rain off their jackets.

"Holly just approved the liner-note booklet layout for *Progress Street*," Evan said, pouring a cup of coffee and looking over Ryan's shoulder at the manuscript pages titled ***Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin***. "And she says when we put out the *Lost Sounds* compilation in a couple of years, we'll remaster *'Sanctuary in the Storm'* and *'Not Her'* from the 1986 two-inch tapes so fans have all five songs of John and Erin's story together."

Ryan looked out the kitchen window toward the wet sidewalk of **Progress Street NE**, leading two blocks southwest toward the stone arches of **Commonwealth Mall**.

All Ryan knew on that rainy June afternoon in 2004 was that if even one brother or sister out there heard *"Before the Distance"*, read the story of John and Erin in the booklet, and stepped in front of the ramp before the steel doors closed, every note on *Progress Street* would have been worth writing.

> **Read the Complete Companion Story (*Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin*):** Experience all four chapters of John and Erin's story at Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute in **Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin (`books.raggiesoft.com/erin`)** and stream the 5-song soundtrack at **`music.raggiesoft.com/playlists/john-and-erin`**.

Book 5: Burnout Hiatus, Our Own Frequency & Neon on the Huckleberry Trail (2005–2014)

Chapter 1: Our Own Frequency, The Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center & Neon on the Huckleberry Trail (2008–2014)

Part 1: The Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center, The $150M Refusal & The Birth of Neon on the Huckleberry Trail

Date: 2014-10-21 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — Thirty Dollars a Month at the Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center

For the first five years of their ten-year Burnout Hiatus (`2005–2015`), **Ryan**, **Cassidy**, **Evan**, **Tyler**, and **Holly** barely left Montgomery County.

In 2008, with the tour buses parked in climate-controlled storage and the arena spotlight switched off, they had set up two condenser microphones in the carpeted living room on **Progress Street NE** and recorded ***Our Own Frequency***—no electric guitars, no stadium drums, just Cassidy's acoustic grand piano, Ryan's fingerpicked acoustic guitar, Evan's upright double bass, and Tyler's brushes on a single snare.

And then, in **July 2010**, six miles down the valley in **Christiansburg**, the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center** opened its doors off **Mill Lane NE** just east of **North Franklin Street**.

Built as a sixty-four-thousand-square-foot joint covenant between the **Town of Christiansburg** and **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute (CPI)**—serving both as the town's public aquatic complex and as **The Forger Natatorium** for CPI's varsity swimming and diving teams—the building was everything Ryan's body had dreamed of since his 1991 aquatic physical therapy sessions at Star City General.

The morning the facility opened in July 2010, CPI's Athletic Director had called Holly's office offering five complimentary lifetime VIP athletic passes for the Class of '89.

Holly had thanked him warmly, hung up the phone, and driven Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler straight down to the front desk in Christiansburg in their **2004 Prairie Coachworks RLFD30** low-floor shuttle to sign up the exact same way every other Blacksburg household did.

Because the facility was owned and operated by the **Town of Christiansburg** and funded by Christiansburg municipal taxes, anyone whose home address was in **Blacksburg**—even six miles up the trail on **Progress Street NE**—fell under the **Non-Resident Rate**: **`$30.00 a month`** per adult on a rolling thirty-day pass.

All five of them gladly paid their thirty dollars a month (`$150.00` a month total) and clipped the plastic barcode keytags onto their swim bags.

By the autumn of 2014, their Tuesday and Thursday afternoon loop had become a sacred family ritual.

At `15:30` on **Tuesday, October 21, 2014**, Ryan pushed his matte-black titanium manual wheelchair through the automatic sliding glass doors of the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center** alongside Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and Holly. One by one, they scanned their non-resident keytags at the front desk scanner—*BEEP, BEEP, BEEP, BEEP, BEEP*—exchanging a warm wave with the Town of Christiansburg teenager working the counter before heading down the tiled corridor to the private, wheelchair-accessible **Family Changing Suites**.

Inside the spacious changing room—equipped with a zero-threshold roll-in shower, stainless-steel grab bars, and a wide fold-down padded transfer bench—Ryan changed into his black swim trunks, transferred smoothly onto one of the facility's waterproof PVC deck wheelchairs, and rolled out onto the warm, humid pool deck.

For the first forty-five minutes, all five of them took over two lanes in the **50-Meter Olympic Competition Pool** beneath the towering ten-meter concrete diving platforms and the maroon-and-orange **`CPI FORGERS SWIMMING & DIVING`** banners hanging from the rafters.

To Ryan, hitting the water was the closest thing on earth to zero gravity. On land, every inch of forward motion required pushing twenty-four-inch aluminum handrims with his shoulders and triceps while managing T10 paraplegic spasticity and three-hour **Protocol T-10** pressure-relief intervals. In the fifty-meter pool, the chair vanished. With thirty years of manual-chair upper-body conditioning powering his freestyle stroke, Ryan cut through the turquoise water alongside Evan and Tyler while Cassidy and Holly raced flip-turns in the adjacent lane.

And at `16:15`, after forty-five minutes of laps, came Ryan's favorite part of the building: **The Cove**.

Tucked beside the zero-depth beach-entry Leisure Pool (where kids were shrieking down the two-story triple-loop yellow water slide), **The Cove** was the facility's dedicated **Warm Water Therapy Pool**, maintained year-round at a constant, spa-like **`95.5°F`**.

Rolling the waterproof deck chair straight down the gentle, non-slip zero-depth ramp into the steaming `95.5°F` water, Ryan floated off the seat and backed up against the underwater hydrotherapy jets with Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and Holly forming a circle around him. Within three minutes, the `95.5°F` thermal buoyancy melted every knot of road-and-trail tension out of his latissimus muscles, his shoulders, and his lower back.

"I'm telling you, Holl," Ryan sighed, resting his head back against the warm tiled coping while the hydrotherapy jets bubbled against his shoulder blades, "OmniCorp offered us a hundred and fifty million dollars last week, and this thirty-dollar-a-month non-resident pass is still a better deal."

Six days earlier, a senior vice president from **OmniCorp Media Group**—the conglomerate that had swallowed their old nemesis, Apex Records—had sent a formal courier packet to Holly's office offering `$150,000,000` cash for a 100% buyout of the **Engine Room Records, LLC** master catalog, conditioned on a five-year mandatory stadium world tour and full commercial re-licensing rights.

Holly had read the offer aloud at the Progress Street dining table, laughed until tears ran down her cheeks, stamped **`REJECTED — NOT FOR SALE AT ANY PRICE`** across the cover sheet in red ink, and mailed it back via certified mail—inspiring the fiery studio track they had just cut in the basement forty-eight hours ago, **"No Strings on the Master"**.

"Best hundred and fifty bucks a month in the budget," Holly grinned from across the `95.5°F` pool, floating on her back. "Zero corporate strings attached."

5:15 PM — Six Miles Back to Blacksburg & A Neighbor's Wave

By `17:00`, showered, dried off, and bundled in warm fleece layers and maroon **CPI** hoodies against the crisp late-October mountain air, the five of them stepped out of the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center**.

Rather than taking a bus or driving up Route 460, all five of them took their favorite route back to Blacksburg together: **the Huckleberry Trail**.

Built over the historic roadbed of the old nineteenth-century **Huckleberry Train**—the slow branch-line railroad that had carried CPI cadets and local families between Christiansburg's **Cambria Depot** and Blacksburg until its final run in 1958—the six-mile paved multi-use rail-trail connected the North Franklin Street corridor in Christiansburg directly to the **Pendleton Library** lawn on the CPI campus.

None of the five of them owned a bicycle; a bike moved far too fast for a family that went everywhere at the pace of Ryan's chair. Instead, as they stepped onto the ten-foot-wide black asphalt path, **Cassidy** took the push-handles behind **Ryan**'s manual wheelchair while **Holly**, **Evan**, and **Tyler** walked side by side right alongside them.

It was **`5:30 PM`** on the dot, and the valley was dressed in its autumn dress.

The late-October air had turned crisp (`48°F`), carrying the sweet, unmistakable scent of chimney woodsmoke curling in silver wisps from the farmhouses along the ridge. Overhead, the towering sugar maples and red oaks bordering the old railroad cut had turned a blazing canopy of crimson, amber, and burnt orange, showering golden leaves across the narrow paved path as Cassidy pushed Ryan's wheelchair and Ryan alternated pushing on his handrims at an easy, conversational pace with Holly, Evan, and Tyler walking shoulder to shoulder beside them.

Two miles north of the Christiansburg ridge, where the trail leveled out between weathered wooden split-rail fences and rolling green pastures dotted with grazing cattle, a group of ten **CPI** undergrads in maroon and orange hoodies came walking and rolling southbound from the direction of campus.

Right at the front of their group was a tall, broad-shouldered freshman guy with a local's easy stride (**Mark Anderson**, who had grown up right down the hill in Radford), walking beside an eighteen-year-old freshman in a black manual wheelchair wearing new rectangular polycarbonate glasses and a maroon CPI hoodie (**Jordan Fuller**), with a blonde young woman (**Aubrie Jean Kelly**) walking close at his left shoulder and their friends (**Madison**, **Zoë**, **Lauren**, **Hannah**, **Sarah**, **Jessica**, and **Isabel**) chatting warmly around them.

Noticeably, the tall kid from Radford spotted the five of them first. His eyes widened for a fraction of a second in quiet recognition—and then, adhering to the unwritten law of the New River Valley, he didn't point, didn't shout, and didn't reach for a camera.

As the two groups passed each other on the narrow asphalt path between the split-rail pasture fences, the freshman in the manual wheelchair looked over at Ryan's chair and smiled, raising one gloved hand in a quiet, respectful neighbor's wave.

Ryan grinned, tapped two fingers to his temple in a warm salute from his handrim, and called out, "Evening, guys! Beautiful night for a roll!"

"Evening!" the tall kid from Radford smiled back, giving a polite nod as Cassidy, Holly, Evan, and Tyler waved warmly and the two groups moved smoothly past each other into the autumn dusk.

No autographs asked. No paparazzi flashes. No security guards. Just neighbors sharing six miles of asphalt in the mountain sanctuary their hometown had given them.

5:42 PM — *"October Five-Thirty and the Air Turns Crisp…"*

A mile further north, as the trail curved toward the southern edge of the **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute** campus, the autumn sun dipped low behind **Price Mountain's crest**, painting the western sky in deep violet and molten gold.

And right at that moment, half a mile ahead above the tree line, all four massive **Ironstone** floodlight towers atop **The Crucible** flickered on for an evening practice —bathing the valley in a warm, shimmering glow of electric light.

Behind Ryan's wheelchair, Cassidy slowed her steps to a halt beneath a crimson sugar maple, resting her hands lightly on the push-handles while Holly, Evan, and Tyler paused beside them.

Ryan braked his handrims and glanced back over his shoulder at her. "Everything okay, Cass?"

Behind her glasses, Cassidy's eyes were fixed on the glowing stadium towers rising above the golden leaves and the quiet paved rail bed stretching back toward the pastures where the ten CPI students had just passed them with nothing more than a warm neighbor's wave. Her right hand was already tapping a buoyant, `124 BPM` eighth-note rhythm against the left push-handle of Ryan's chair.

"Ry," Cassidy whispered, her voice catching with a sudden, luminous smile. "Those kids in the hoodies back by the pasture—and that boy in the manual chair who waved to you without asking for a thing. Listen to the cadence of your wheels on the leaves. We need to write a thank-you song for our neighbors."

She sang it softly into the cool October wind—an effortless, soaring `D Major` melody that began with the exact time they had stepped onto the trail at `5:30 PM`:

> *"October five-thirty and the air turns crisp Woodsmoke curling in a silver wisp Maples turning crimson by the old rail bed Canopy of burnt orange overhead You're pushing on your hand-rims at an easy pace With the mountain wind cooling off your face Six miles of asphalt from the library lawn Where the old Huckleberry train used to roll on*
>
> *No studio clocks and no city stress Just the valley dressed in its autumn dress Watch the sun dip low behind Price Mountain's crest In the quiet corner that we love the best!"*

Ryan, Evan, Tyler, and Holly looked at Cassidy in quiet awe. Without needing a guitar in his hands, Ryan heard the chorus and the second verse—about the cattle pastures and the students in their hoodies who had just given them a neighbor's wave—rising right out of the valley around them, and he sang the lines back to his sister in close sibling harmony while Evan and Tyler tapped the beat against their thighs:

> *"Chasing the neon on the Huckleberry Trail! Where the twilight glows and the shadows sail! Spinning our wheels through the golden leaves Underneath a sky that still believes! See the stadium towers flicker on in the night Painting the valley in electric light! Every autumn evening tells the same old tale We're home together on the Huckleberry Trail!*

> *Passing by the pastures where the cattle graze Wrapped inside the amber of the college days Students in their hoodies jogging two by two Nodding with a smile as we roll on through No autographs asked, just a neighbor's wave In the mountain sanctuary that our hometown gave Thirty years of music and we still belong To the winding path where we wrote this song!"*

Cassidy's face lit up with pure, unburdened joy. She pulled her voice recorder out of her jacket pocket, hit `RECORD` so they wouldn't lose a single note of the arrangement before reaching the **Pendleton Library** lawn, and tucked it back into her zip pocket.

Then she stepped out beside Ryan's right wheel on the flat straightaway toward campus, looked down at her brother with a mischievous twenty-year-old grin, and called out on foot:

"Race you back to Progress Street!"

Ryan laughed out loud, leaned forward in his chair, and gripped both titanium handrims:

"You're on, Cass!"

That night in the basement studio on **Progress Street NE**, Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler recorded **"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"** in two takes—keeping Cassidy's playful challenge and Ryan's answer right at the very end of the master tape as a warm thank-you card to their neighbors for ten years of peace on the six-mile path between Christiansburg and home.

Part 2: Forty-One Degrees in the Rain, The RLFD30 Kneeling Ramp & Ninety-Five Point Five in The Cove

Date: 2014-11-18 at 15:15 America/New_York

November 18, 2014 • 3:15 PM — Why Forty-One-Degree Rain Changes the Math

Four weeks after the golden October sunset that had given birth to ***"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"***, November arrived in Montgomery County with teeth.

At `15:15` on Tuesday, November 18, 2014, a cold, driving forty-one-degree Appalachian rainstorm lashed sideways down **Progress Street NE**, stripping the last amber leaves from the oaks and sending sheets of icy water rushing down the storm gutters toward **Commonwealth Mall**.

Inside the warm foyer of the house on Progress Street, **Ryan O'Connell** sat in his matte-black titanium manual wheelchair beside his sisters **Cassidy** and **Holly** and their twin cousins **Evan** and **Tyler Wright**,swim bags slung over their shoulders for their Tuesday afternoon trip to the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center** in Christiansburg.

On a clear afternoon, the five of them loved walking and rolling the **Huckleberry Trail** home from the pool.

In forty-one-degree pouring rain, however, rolling a manual wheelchair outdoors across Montgomery County wasn't just uncomfortable—for a man with a complete **T10 spinal cord injury**, it was a serious medical and mechanical hazard that the five of them had learned to respect over twenty-four years since the December 10, 1990 crash:

1. **Wet Titanium Handrims & Braking Loss:** Even with Ryan's carbon-fiber fender splash-guards snapped over his twenty-four-inch rear tires and his textured neoprene wet-weather push gloves strapped to his hands, driving rains turned anodized titanium handrims slick as wet glass—cutting downhill braking friction by more than half on steep Blacksburg grades.
2. **T10 Poikilothermia & Autonomic Dysreflexia Risk:** Below the tenth thoracic vertebra (`T10`), Ryan's autonomic nervous system could neither shiver to generate heat nor constrict blood vessels efficiently against cold water—and because he had zero sensation below his navel, freezing rainwater soaking into his jeans or pooling on his pressure-relief seat cushion could drop his core temperature into hypothermia or trigger a dangerous autonomic dysreflexia blood-pressure spike before he ever felt his legs getting cold.
3. **Keeping the Pressure-Relief Cushion Bone-Dry:** A wet high-density gel-and-foam wheelchair cushion softened the skin-surface barrier and took a full day to dry, creating an immediate pressure-injury risk during his strict three-hour **Protocol T-10** intervals.

In their twenties, right after the 1990 crash, Ryan had once tried to tough out a cold November rainstorm on campus in a standard rain jacket—ending up soaked to the skin with a core temperature of `95.1°F` and his sister Cassidy crying beside a space heater while Evan and Tyler wrapped him in heated blankets.

After that night, the family had established an ironclad rule for cold mountain rain: **the Contoured Seated Rain Cape, dry microfiber wheel towels, and Unit 02**.

3:20 PM — Unit 02 at the Porch Apron

"Nobody's touching a wet sidewalk today," **Tyler** announced, pulling on his hooded waterproof shell and grabbing the keys to **Unit 02**—their thirty-foot **2004 Prairie Coachworks RLFD30** low-floor executive shuttle (*"Progress Street Shuttle"*, Launch Customer Serial `#001`). "Give me ninety seconds to pull her right up to the covered driveway apron."

While Tyler jogged out to the climate-controlled coach bay behind the studio, **Cassidy** and **Holly** helped Ryan snap on his custom charcoal **Wheelchair Rain Cape**—draped long in front over his knees and footplate and cut short in back above the backrest frame so not a drop of blown mist could touch his jeans or his pressure-relief cushion—while Ryan slipped his hands into his high-friction neoprene wet-weather push gloves.

Ninety seconds later, the deep, quiet purr of the **Prairie Coachworks RLFD30** echoed under the rain-hammered carport awning on **Progress Street NE**, its amber front LED destination sign glowing warmly through the grey downpour:

`PROGRESS STREET`

Holding his Class A CDL with Passenger and Airbrake endorsements, Tyler brought the single-door thirty-foot coach to a halt six inches from the covered concrete porch apron. He flipped the pneumatic suspension switch on the dash.

With a soft *hiss* of compressed air, the front axle of the coach kneeled four inches down to meet the dry concrete apron, the wide front transit doors folded open under the carport roof, and the five-second front flip-out aluminum **ADA wheelchair ramp** deployed straight onto the dry porch at a gentle, almost flat incline.

Without a single drop of forty-one-degree rain touching his cushion or his legs, Ryan pushed smoothly up the non-slip ramp into the warm, carpeted seventy-two-degree acoustic lounge of the coach, backing into his integrated four-point **Q'Straint** securement bay behind the front wheel well while **Evan** locked the floor retractors in ten seconds flat and Cassidy and Holly climbed aboard behind him.

3:40 PM — Ninety-Five Point Five Degrees Under a Rain-Swept Skylight

Fifteen minutes later down in **Christiansburg**, Tyler pulled the **Prairie Coachworks RLFD30** straight up to the covered drop-off canopy outside the automatic sliding glass doors of the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center** off **Mill Lane NE** (`90 seconds` later parking the thirty-foot shuttle cleanly across the oversized RV/bus pull-through spaces at the edge of the lot).

BEEP, BEEP, BEEP, BEEP, BEEP.

All five of them scanned their **`$30.00/month` Town of Christiansburg Non-Resident** barcode keytags at the front desk, dried the tires of Ryan's titanium chair with the microfiber towel from his under-seat pouch inside the private **Family Changing Suite**, transferred Ryan onto the facility's waterproof PVC deck wheelchair, and rolled out onto the warm natatorium deck.

After forty minutes of brisk freestyle laps in the **50-Meter Olympic Competition Pool** (*The Forger Natatorium*) to get their hearts pumping, the five of them rolled over to **The Cove**—the facility's **`95.5°F` Warm Water Therapy Pool**—and glided down the zero-depth ramp into the steaming turquoise water.

Floating weightless in the `95.5°F` thermal water with the underwater hydrotherapy jets massaging his lower back and shoulders while **Cassidy**, **Holly**, **Evan**, and **Tyler** floated in a circle beside him, Ryan tilted his head back and looked up at the high clerestory windows and skylights of the natatorium.

Forty feet above their heads, the cold forty-one-degree November rainstorm was hammering against the thick insulated glass in silver sheets, wind howling off the Blue Ridge crest outside.

Down here in **The Cove**, wrapped in ninety-five-point-five-degree water with his sisters and his twin cousins around him, his muscles were completely loose, his core temperature was rock-steady, and the storm couldn't touch him.

"Look at the rain coming down on that skylight," **Cassidy** murmured, floating beside Ryan's right shoulder with her glasses resting safely in the dry deck cubby and a contented smile on her face. "Forty-one degrees and pouring outside, and ninety-five-point-five down here."

“Best thirty-dollar-a-month non-resident pass on earth,” **Holly** grinned, resting her arms along the warm tiled coping beside Evan and Tyler. “And when we’re done soaking, Tyler pulls the thirty-foot low-floor shuttle right up to the canopy door and drops us back under the porch roof on Progress Street without a single wet seat cushion.”

“Eat your heart out, Mother Nature,” Ryan laughed, splashing a gentle wave of warm water toward his sisters and cousins as the November rain drummed a steady rhythm on the roof high above them.

Book 6: Reignition & Live at the Crucible (2015–2016)

Chapter 1: Live at the Crucible (May 21, 2016)

Part 1: Protocol T-10, The $15M Lockout & Operation Anvil

Date: 2016-05-21 at 15:00 America/New_York

3:00 PM — Protocol T-10 & The Four-Hour Clock

At `15:00` on Saturday, May 21, 2016, the digital aviation chronometer mounted to the corner of **Ryan O’Connell**’s guitar tech bench inside the South End Zone visiting locker room of **The Crucible** chimed twice.

Ryan didn’t need to look up from the fretboard of his 1986 cherry-sunburst solid-body electric guitar to know what the chime meant. Twenty-five years and five months after the black ice on **Interstate 81** at **Mile Marker 98** near Newbern, Virginia had severed his spinal cord at the tenth thoracic vertebra, his body didn’t run on rock-and-roll time anymore. It ran on **Protocol T-10**.

“Three o’clock, Ry,” **Cassidy** said softly from the corner of the concrete locker room, setting down her thermos of warm lemon-and-honey tea beside her vintage eight-voice analog polysynth flight case. Even at fifty—dressed in her vintage maroon **CPI Class of 1989** alumni T-shirt with her black leather stage jacket draped over the back of her chair—his younger sister still had that quiet, watchful radar that never turned off around him. “Four hours to the seven-o’clock pre-launch check. Have you finished the electrolyte bottle?”

“Last ounce right here,” Ryan said, smiling as he set his polishing cloth across the guitar strings, drained the measured sixteen-ounce bottle of water, and pressed his palms down against the anodized push-rims of his titanium manual wheelchair to lift his hips clear of the cushion for fifteen seconds.

On the road, that four-hour hydration and intermittent catheterization clock was the unseen metronome behind every show **The Stardust Engine** played. In a three-hour stadium concert with no intermission, there was no ducking behind an amplifier stack if he misjudged his fluid intake, and there was no forgiving a missed pressure-relief shift when he was locked under hot stage lights with a ten-pound mahogany

guitar strapped across his chest. At `15:00`, he hydrated and stretched; at `19:00`—sixty minutes before stage call—he and Cassidy would lock the green-room door for his final pre-show catheterization and leg-spasm stretches so he could roll onto the stage deck at `20:00` with a clear four-hour window through the final chord of the night.

The locker-room door swung open, and identical twins **Evan** and **Tyler Wright** walked in carrying two foil-wrapped trays that filled the concrete room with the unmistakable, mouthwatering aroma of hickory-smoked pulled pork and vinegar slaw.

“Alright, don’t nobody touch the talent’s guitar until he eats,” Tyler grinned, setting a tray down on the flight case beside Ryan while Evan handed a second container to Cassidy. “Courtesy of the **Forger Nation Tailgate Plaza** out in the East Lot. The line at the Smokin’ Anvil smokers is already wrapped all the way past the **Crucible Bus Loop**, and the **Blue Ridge Transit** articulated shuttles are dropping off another two hundred students every ninety seconds.”

Ryan took a forkful of the warm pulled pork and looked up as their younger sister—and **Engine Room Records, LLC** Chief Executive Officer—**Holly O’Connell** strode into the locker room in a tailored maroon blazer with a CPI lanyard around her neck and a MagnaPad Pro tablet tucked under her arm.

“Let me guess,” Ryan said, pointing his fork at Holly’s tablet. “The ticket brokers in New York and Atlanta are still threatening to sue you?”

Holly’s mouth curved into the razor-sharp smile that had terrified corporate record executives since she was sixteen years old.

“Let them try,” Holly said, tapping her screen to bring up the live gate telemetry from the stadium turnstiles. “As of two minutes ago, all thirty-five thousand Field Level, Lower Bowl, and Accessible Terrace seats purchased through the **CPI Poly Pass** portal are ninety-four percent checked in at the gates. Zero secondary-market transfers. Zero dynamic-pricing markups. Every undergraduate, grad student, and faculty member down on that turf paid twenty-five dollars—or five dollars with their student activity fee waiver—and got a commemorative gold-foil lanyard and a five-dollar tailgate plate.”

Ryan looked at his younger sister with a quiet ache of pride in his chest. When the national stadium promoters had pitched this May 21 homecoming tour finale back in the winter, they had projected a `$15,000,000` gross if Engine Room Records turned on “Platinum Dynamic Pricing” and let secondary brokers auction the lower bowl for eight hundred dollars a seat.

Holly hadn’t even let them finish the slide deck. Citing **Addendum No. 3** to the famous **`$1.00` Perpetual Mutual Cross-License** she had drafted on notebook paper in their kitchen on **Progress Street** in 1986, she had used the **Forger Nation Trust** to buy out all 35,000 lower-bowl and field seats upfront and sold them at strict production cost through CPI’s Zero-Knowledge `SAML 2.0` Poly Pass authentication portal. If a student’s schedule changed, the ticket could only be returned to the portal at face value for the next Forger in line.

“We left fifteen million dollars on the table,” Evan said, leaning against his touring bass amplifier rack with a grin, “and there isn’t a single corporate VIP suit in the first forty rows. Just sixty-five thousand Ironheads in maroon and orange.”

“That’s who built this band,” Cassidy said quietly, looking down at her hands. “In 1993, when we couldn’t even afford to heat the warehouse and every radio station in America had our name on a do-not-play memo, it was CPI students copying **The Warehouse Tapes** in their dorm rooms who kept us alive. Tonight belongs to them.”

5:30 PM — Operation Anvil (“Exercise 87-B”)

At `17:30`, after the five-piece **Orbital Crew** touring section—rhythm guitarist **Marcus Vance**, auxiliary drummer **Darius “Doc” Holloway**, synth player **Claire Lindqvist**, and CPI Music Department faculty soloists **Prof. Julian Vance** and **Elena Rostova**—wrapped up line check out on the main stage, Ryan unlocked his brakes and rolled down the wide concrete service tunnel behind Cassidy and Holly toward the Indoor Practice Facility.

Inside, all three hundred uniformed members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** stood in formation in their maroon-and-orange wool uniforms and plumed shakos, their brass instruments gleaming under the high-bay lights while **“The Engine Room”**—the high-tension Kevlar snare and tenors battery—adjusted their harnesses.

When the double doors opened and Ryan rolled in alongside Cassidy and Holly, three hundred pairs of eyes snapped to attention, and a spontaneous wave of applause echoed off the steel rafters.

“**Marching Forgers**, ten-hut!” Director of Athletic Bands **Dr. Arthur Vance** called from the podium before smiling warmly down at the trio. “Class of ’89, the field is yours.”

Ryan wheeled up to the front of the formation beside Cassidy, looking out at three hundred college students who were the exact age he, Cassidy, and their twin cousins Evan and Tyler had been when they recorded a four-track cassette in a cold garage on Progress Street thirty years ago.

“First of all,” Ryan said, his voice carrying clearly across the silent practice hall, “thank you for sharing your house with us tonight. Every stadium we’ve played on this tour has had a bigger press box or a fancier VIP lounge, and none of them—not one—sounds like **The Crucible** when the sun goes down and the brass line hits the tunnel.”

A fierce murmur of *“Go Forgers!”* rippled through the horn line.

Holly stepped forward, holding up a single sheet of legal parchment bearing the crimson wax seal of the Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute Bursar’s Office.

“For the last eight weeks,” Holly said, her voice brisk and deadpan, “you’ve all been rehearsing a piece of music labeled ***‘Exercise 87-B: The Anvil Finale’*** under **Addendum No. 4** to the 1986 Cross-License. And as of `17:30` today, the CPI Office of Legal Counsel and Engine Room Records have verified that across three hundred student musicians, zero cell-phone recordings, zero social-media videos, and zero setlist leaks have appeared anywhere on the internet.”

The snare line exchanged wide grins.

“Which means,” Holly continued, allowing herself a warm smile, “at `00:01` tonight, the **$300,000 Forger Pot** in the CPI Student Escrow Account officially unlocks. One thousand dollars per musician will be credited directly to your Fall 2016 Bursar tuition accounts—with any overage paid out to you as an unrestricted fellowship stipend on Monday morning.”

Three hundred brass and percussion players erupted into a deafening cheer, lifting their horns and drumsticks toward the ceiling until Cassidy raised both hands with a laugh.

“Now, there’s one reason none of you recognized *‘Exercise 87-B’* while you were learning it,” Cassidy said, her hazel eyes sparkling. “When I arranged the brass charts in February, I left the lead vocal melody completely off the page, and I wrote a brand-new seventy-seven-second stadium rock overture for the front of it. Out there tonight, at the end of Act VI, we’re going to play **‘Last Bus Home: Lights Out on Progress Street’** and turn every light in the stadium off. Sixty-five thousand people are going to think the concert is over.”

Ryan tapped the cherry-sunburst body of his electric guitar resting across his knees.

“That’s when all three hundred of you are going to march right back up the stage ramps in the pitch dark,” Ryan said. “And for the first minute and forty seconds of that overture, nobody in the stands—not even the alumni down in the front row—is going to have any idea what song we’re playing. Until `1:40`, when the horns drop out, Tyler hits the kick drum, and Cassidy sings the very first line we ever released in 1987—the way it was *supposed* to sound before a record label in Los Angeles tried to turn us into a synth-pop band.”

In the front row of the trumpet section, a senior squad leader grinned from ear to ear. “Wait—*‘Exercise 87-B’* is **‘Electric Color’**?!”

“In 1980s Stadium Rock,” Cassidy smiled. “Let’s go blow the roof off the valley.”

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller’s POV):** Read this exact `15:00–19:30` pre-show window from the Crucible Shuttle, the Forger Nation Tailgate Plaza, and `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 1: *The Crucible Shuttle & The Forger Nation Tailgate*** • Explore the band’s full cosmic archive at `stardust.raggiesoft.com`.

Part 2: Act I: The Anvil Strike & The Marching Forgers

Date: 2016-05-21 at 19:55 America/New_York

7:55 PM — Five Minutes to Ignition

At `19:55`, parked in the dark wing at the top of the stage-left hydraulic ramp with his 1986 sunburst electric guitar strapped across his chest, **Ryan O’Connell** looked out past the black stage curtains into a sight that took the breath right out of his lungs.

Sixty-five thousand people filled the towering Gothic **Ironstone** bowl of **The Crucible** from the turf all the way up to the highest floodlight catwalks against the indigo Appalachian twilight. There was no opening band tonight. There were no corporate sponsor banners hanging from the balconies—only a sea of Foundry Maroon and Molten Orange, and the low, electric hum of sixty-five thousand **Forgers** waiting for four alumni from the Class of 1989 to come home.

Beside Ryan in the wing, **Holly** stood next to the **Engine Room Films** mobile director's monitor bank, watching the live feeds from the twenty-four-foot counterweighted camera cranes sweeping along the fifty-yard line.

"Look at Camera Three on the accessible terrace at `Section 104, Row A`," Cassidy whispered, leaning a hand gently on the push-handle of Ryan's chair as she looked at the monitor.

On the high-definition screen, the crane lens was gliding three feet above the front railing of `Section 104, Row A`. Right in `Seat 1`, a young man in a custom manual wheelchair—wearing rectangular glasses, a Foundry Maroon `CPI` shirt, and a gold-foil ticket lanyard—was grinning from ear to ear and waving up at the camera alongside a radiant blonde woman in an orange scarf, a tall blonde friend with a pink ribbon in her hair, an athletic guy in a maroon polo, and a dark-haired girl holding a digital tablet.

Ryan did a double-take at the screen, a warm grin breaking across his face.

"Wait a second, Cass," Ryan said softly, leaning closer to the monitor. "That's the kid from the **Huckleberry Trail**—the freshman in the manual chair who waved to us between the pastures back in October '14, right before you wrote *'Huckleberry Trail'*!"

Ryan had never gotten the young man's name that afternoon on the trail, and because of the unwritten rule of Blacksburg, nobody had stopped to make introductions. Yet seeing that same manual wheelchair user sitting right at the fifty-yard line of **The Crucible** nineteen months later—surrounded by people who clearly loved him fiercely, without an ounce of fear or overwhelm in his eyes—made something warm tighten in Ryan's chest. More than anything, Ryan realized, he wanted to actually meet that kid one day—not as a musician meeting a fan, but simply to say hello and talk shop with another manual wheelchair user in town.

"Put a flag on that timecode for the Blu-ray edit," Ryan told the video director softly, making a mental note to keep his eye on `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` all night. "That kid in `Section 104, Seat 1` goes in the opening montage."

At `19:59`, **Evan** bumped his fist against Ryan's shoulder, **Tyler** twirled his hickory drumsticks before climbing onto the center drum riser, and **Cassidy** kissed Ryan's temple before stepping out into the dark toward her wraparound analog synthesizer rig.

"Have fun out there, big brother," she whispered.

8:00 PM — Act I, Track 1: *"Ignition: The Forger's Call"*

At `20:00` on the dot, every floodlight tower inside **The Crucible** cut to pitch black.

The roar that rose from sixty-five thousand throats in the sudden darkness didn't just hit Ryan's ears; it vibrated straight up through the caster forks of his wheelchair and into his ribs. Through the darkness of the stadium bowl, the massive field-level gates at the North and South tunnels swung wide, and all **three hundred uniformed members of the CPI Marching Forgers**—thirty gleaming brass sousaphones, rows of trumpets, mellophones, and trombones, and **"The Engine Room"** Kevlar snare and bass drum battery—filed up the flanking stage ramps in locked six-to-five military precision to fill the upper tiers of the stadium stage.

Over a faint, warm analog synthesizer pad humming from Cassidy's center-stage riser, a solitary crisp white spotlight cut through the dark onto the front-left lip of the stage.

Ryan released his wheel locks, gave two strong, smooth pushes on his titanium handrims, and rolled out to his lowered boom microphone at the edge of the stage deck. Resting his right palm over the strings of his electric guitar as he looked up at the steepest stands in college football, Ryan leaned into the microphone, his gravelly voice echoing intimately across the sixty-five-thousand-seat valley:

> *"Thirty years ago… We were just five kids in a garage on Progress Street. We didn't have a record deal… We didn't have a tour bus… All we had was a cassette tape… and an idea."*

Across the dark bowl, sixty-five thousand people leaned forward as Ryan's voice rose to a commanding roar:

> *"We entered a contest to write a song for this stadium. We wanted to make something loud enough… To scare the HELL out of anyone who dared to come into our house!"*

The entire stadium erupted in a tidal wave of cheers as Ryan grinned out at the sea of Foundry Maroon and Molten Orange:

> *"For thirty years… you guys have been stomping your feet to our song every single Saturday. So tonight… for the 30th Anniversary… Let's see if we can break the seismographs!"*

Back on the center riser, **Tyler** unleashed a massive, thundering drum fill across his double-kick kit, and Ryan threw his head back and screamed into the microphone:

"IGNITION!"

Sixty-five thousand voices roared back as one:

"IGNITION!"

In the dark, Tyler brought his forged-iron sledgehammer down onto his unmuffled steel brake-drum anvil (`TING...`), and across the entire stadium—led by the student section in **The Anvil**—sixty-five thousand fans slammed their right boots down onto the galvanized steel bleachers and concrete decks on the upbeat (`BOOM!`):

TING… BOOM!

TING… BOOM!

Ryan felt the stage deck flexing half an inch beneath his wheelchair tires—knowing that half a mile away in **Copernicus Hall**, the Geosciences seismographs were already spiking in the green. As pyrotechnic columns of Foundry Maroon and Molten Orange shot fifty feet into the night sky behind the stage truss, Tyler's double-kick drums and **The Engine Room**'s thirty Kevlar marching snares slammed into the heavy, slow-stomping `82 BPM` industrial groove, Evan's bass locked in beneath Cassidy's blazing analog synthesizer brass, and Ryan screamed out the iconic 1986 stadium entrance riff of **"Ignition: The Forger's Call"**:

> *"The lights go dark… the tension builds… A single pounding heavy sound… The hammer striking on the steel… It shakes the air… it shakes the ground! T he pressure's on… the time is now… We're here to forge our name! The spark is lit… the fire burns—"*

Leaning into his center microphone, Ryan shouted a ferocious live ad-lib straight at the scoreboard above the South End Zone:

> ***"We're taking the Anchor BACK to the Mountains!"***

And all sixty-five thousand Forgers thundered the chorus back across the night sky:

> **RYAN & CASSIDY:** *"IGNITION!"* **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"IGNITION!"*** **RYAN & CASSIDY:** *"This is the Forger's Call! IGNITION!"* **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"IGNITION!"*** **RYAN & CASSIDY:** *"We're standing ten feet tall! We are the hammer, we're the flame— This is our house, this is our game!"*

8:05 PM — Act I, Tracks 2 & 3: *"CPI Tech Triumph"* & *"The Stardust Engine"*

The instant the final pyrotechnic burst of *"Ignition"* echoed off the upper deck, Tyler snapped four crisp snare rimshots as Drum Major **Sarah Jenkins** blew four piercing blasts on her silver whistle (`Tweet-Tweet-Tweet-Tweet!`), and **"The Engine Room"**—the high-tension Kevlar marching snare line—ripped straight into the `138 BPM` roll-off of **"CPI Tech Triumph: The Marching Forgers"**.

Grinning over at Evan as his cousin locked his four-string bass into the thirty-sousaphone bassline, Ryan doubled the century-old 1912 fight song melody on overdriven electric guitar while sixty-five thousand students and alumni clapped in unbroken time and spelled out the call-and-response across the night sky:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"C! — P! — I! FORGERS! FIGHT! FORGERS! WIN! CPI!"***

And instead of marching off the field when the fight song ended, all three hundred Marching Forgers held their formation across the wide stage wings.

"Keep the Marching Forgers right here with us!" Cassidy called into her microphone as the stadium lights shifted from Foundry Maroon to deep cosmic violet.

Ryan rolled forward to his mic, looking out at the sea of glowing faces as orbital telemetry coordinates ticked upward from `1986` to `2016` across the 120-foot curved LED wall behind them.

“Thirty years ago in 1986,” Ryan shouted over the roar, “Evan and Tyler walked into our basement and we wrote our very first song together about the cosmos and the rockets that get you there! Let’s hear it, CPI!”

Across center stage, Cassidy’s fingers dropped onto her analog synthesizer manual, and the shimmering, cosmic 1986 arpeggio of **“The Stardust Engine”** cascaded across the stadium.

Looking across the stage at his sister, Ryan felt a lump rise in his throat. Thirty years ago, when the four of them had written this song in 1986, they had been too scared to even play it for a talent scout, so they had taken its name as their band name instead—**Stardust** for their love of the cosmos, and **Engine** for the rockets to get you there. Later, when Apex Records signed them, the label’s marketing department had twisted that name into a cheap corporate gimmick, branding Cassidy as their *“Stardust”* and Ryan as their *“Engine”*.

Tonight, backed by three hundred brass and percussion players from their own alma mater, there were no corporate gimmicks left—only the song that had started it all. When Cassidy’s vocal soared into the chorus (*“We are the Stardust Engine! / Racing through the night / We’re burning on the fuel of a brand new light!”*) and three hundred collegiate trumpets, mellophones, and trombones answered her synthesizer hook in a wall of live brass, Ryan leaned back against his backrest and bent the twentieth fret of his electric guitar toward the Blacksburg stars.

As the final chord echoed across the Blue Ridge foothills, Cassidy saluted the three hundred student musicians:

“Give it up for our alma mater’s pride and joy—the three-hundred-strong **CPI Marching Forgers**!” Cassidy cheered as the stadium roared and the marching band filed proudly down the flanking ramps into the tunnel—leaving everyone in the stadium convinced the marching band’s guest appearance for the night was over.

Across the stage deck, Ryan caught Cassidy’s eye and winked.

Just wait until 10:45, he thought.

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller’s POV):** Read Act I (`19:55–20:25`) from the front railing of `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` as the camera crane sweeps overhead and the 300 CPI Marching Forgers take the stage in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 2: *The Anvil Strike & The Marching Forgers*** • Explore the band’s full cosmic archive at **`stardust.raggiesoft.com`**.

Part 3: Act II: The Orbital Crew, Not Your Doll & Fifty-Two to Nothing

Date: 2016-05-21 at 20:25 America/New_York

8:25 PM — Zero Backing Tracks & *"Not Your Doll"*

As the main body of the **CPI Marching Forgers** filed into the South End Zone tunnel, a sharp twenty-piece brass and drumline honor guard remained at attention along the upper back tier of the stage, standing beside the five musicians stationed on the stage-left riser.

Ryan did a quick fifteen-second pressure lift on his handrims, rolled back up to his center-left boom mic, and gestured toward the stage-left riser.

"Before we go any further tonight," Ryan told the sixty-five thousand fans filling the bowl, "there's a rule the four of us made in 1986 that we've never broken: **you will never hear a pre-recorded backing track at a Stardust Engine show.** Every synth pad, every harmony, every horn blast, and every drum fill you hear tonight is played live by human hands! Make some noise for our **Orbital Crew**—**Marcus Vance** on rhythm guitar and twelve-string, **Darius 'Doc' Holloway** on second kit and percussion, **Claire Lindqvist** on auxiliary analog synthesizers, and straight out of the CPI Music Department faculty, **Professor Julian Vance** on trumpet and **Elena Rostova** on saxophone!"

The student section roared for their own faculty professors as a rocket-launch countdown clock flashed across the 120-foot screen behind them.

"There's no opening act tonight, Blacksburg, and we aren't pacing ourselves!" Ryan called out, grinning into his center mic. "Hold onto your seats! *Guidance is internal. T-minus ten… nine… eight… Seven… six… Main Engine Start! Four… three… two… one… Zero! Liftoff!*"

Tyler and Doc locked their double drum kits into the explosive `142 BPM` pulse of **"Main Engine Start"**, with all sixty-five thousand fans counting down from ten to liftoff before the band tore straight into the heavy, grinding industrial-rock thunder of 1997's **"Hard Reset"**.

As the final chord of *"Hard Reset"* rang out, Ryan watched **Cassidy** do something she always savored on this tour.

Stepping out from behind her wraparound synthesizer fortress—leaving Claire Lindqvist to carry the main keyboard patch—Cassidy shrugged on her studded black leather biker jacket over her maroon CPI Class of 1989 shirt, strode all the way out to the front-center lip of the stadium stage directly beside Ryan's wheelchair, and gripped the chrome stand microphone with both hands.

Above the stage, the 120-foot curved LED wall flickered with a giant, glossy 1980s neon-pink porcelain doll mask bound in golden chains.

"Back in nineteen eighty-seven," Cassidy's voice rang out across the stadium—raw, fierce, and razor-sharp, "a record executive in a three-thousand-dollar suit looked at my brother and me and decided that a girl from Blacksburg wasn't allowed to play heavy rock and roll! They pointed at Ryan and called him the *Engine*… and they pointed at me, handed me a pink plastic script, and told me to smile, stay quiet behind the keyboards, and be their little *Stardust*! Well, tonight I'm standing front and center in our house—and nobody puts a cage around this voice ever again!"

On a thunderous dual-kit drum detonation from Tyler and Doc Holloway, twin fountains of white-hot gold and crimson pyrotechnic sparks erupted thirty feet into the night air along the stage edge—Ryan feeling the wave of heat across his forearms—while the porcelain doll mask on the 120-foot screen shattered into roaring flames behind bold rock lettering reading **`NOT YOUR DOLL`**, and Ryan and Marcus Vance locked into the crunching, palm-muted twin-guitar riff of **"Not Your Doll"**:

> *"You painted on a smile and you locked the door Said a girl shouldn't roar on the stadium floor You wanted sugar-coated, polite and tame While you cashed every check written out in our name! Tear up the contract, shatter the glass! Watch your little empire crumble and pass! I'm stepping out from behind the keys— Down on the front line, off of my knees! 'CAUSE I'M NOT YOUR DOLL! I'M NOT YOUR PRETTY TOY! I'M NOT JUST A PICTURE FOR A POSTER BOY! I'M NOT YOUR DOLL! I'M HERE TO MAKE A CHOICE— AND I'M GONNA MAKE YOU HEAR MY VOICE!"*

Sitting two feet to her left, watching his younger sister command sixty-five thousand people at the front edge of the stage without a keyboard rack to hide behind, Ryan grinned so wide his cheeks hurt. When they dropped the guitars out to pounding dual stadium drums on the breakdown and Cassidy yelled, *"Let me hear every voice in The Crucible tonight—if nobody owns you, scream it back to me!"*, sixty-five thousand voices thundered back as one:

> **`"NOT YOUR DOLL!"`**

8:40 PM — *"Fifty-Two to Nothing: The Norfolk Reckoning"*

After tearing straight into the gritty garage-rock pulse of 1995's **"Static"** and saluting Evan and Tyler's decades behind the wheel on Interstate 81 with 2001's **"Midnight Drivers"**—Ryan spinning effortlessly on his rear wheels during his guitar solo—Ryan rolled forward to the center microphone as twilight settled into deep Appalachian night.

He pointed the neck of his sunburst electric guitar straight across the stadium bowl toward the towering **North End Zone LED Scoreboard** above **The Anvil**.

Every CPI alumnus and student in the building knew the ugly scar from two autumns ago—September 2014, when the **Virginia Dominion University (`VDU`) Admirals** had walked into The Crucible on Homecoming Saturday and humiliated the Forgers `38–0` in a relentless rainstorm. Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and Holly had watched that game from the Alumni Box, and they had been in the stands down in Norfolk a year later when CPI went into VDU's house and settled the ledger in blood and iron: **52–0**.

"Hey, Forger Nation," Ryan said into his microphone, a wicked, knowing grin spreading across his face as the crowd began to buzz. "Two autumns ago, in September 2014, a certain football team from down in Norfolk walked into this house on Homecoming and put an ugly number up on that North End Zone board. And then last October, when our guys traveled down Interstate 64 to Norfolk for *their* Homecoming… their student section had the nerve to print up ten thousand T-shirts with that old score on their chests."

Sixty-five thousand CPI fans booed in gleeful, unified indignation.

High above the Gothic limestone arches of the North End Zone, the giant stadium scoreboard flickered to life, displaying the ghostly, hated numerals from September 2014 (`HOME: 0 — VISITOR: 38`)—and then, on a thunderous marching snare roll from Tyler, digital flames of Foundry Maroon and Molten Orange shattered the old numbers off the screen, locking in thirty-foot-tall blazing gold digits:

> **`CPI FORGERS: 52 — VDU ADMIRALS: 0`**

"How'd those T-shirts look by the fourth quarter, Forger Nation?!" Cassidy roared into her mic as the stadium erupted into one of the loudest ovations of the night. "This is **'Fifty-Two to Nothing: The Norfolk Reckoning'**!"

The roar inside The Crucible was so loud it nearly clipped Ryan's custom in-ear monitors. As he wheeled over toward the stage-right ramp during the second chorus, his eyes swept across the accessible terrace at `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`.

There, backlit by the molten-orange glow of the field LEDs, the young man in the manual wheelchair with the rectangular glasses had his right fist raised high in the air toward the `52–0` scoreboard, shouting every word of the chorus at the top of his lungs while his friends clapped his shoulders and cheered around him:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"FIFTY-TWO TO NOTHING! PUT IT ON THE BOARD! HEAR THE MIGHTY THUNDER OF THE FORGER CHORD! YOU WORE THE OLD NUMBERS ON YOUR HOMECOMING CHEST — TILL THE MOUNTAINS CAME DOWN AND PUT THE TALK TO REST!"***

Ryan didn't know the kid's name, and he didn't know what that `38–0` afternoon in 2014 had cost him—but seeing the look of pure, weightless liberation on that young man's face as he stared up at `52–0`, Ryan lifted his right hand off his guitar strings for two beats and pointed a salute straight across the turf toward `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`.

When the stadium finally finished roaring the `52–0` chorus, Cassidy walked over toward the stage-right wing and pointed down into the monitor bunker, where **Holly** stood in her tailored maroon blazer beside the recording engineers.

"This next one is from the *Lost Sounds* vault—for our little sister Holly, who took a one-dollar bill in nineteen eighty-six and saved our lives!" Cassidy called out, launching the band into two blistering rarities from their 2007 archival compilation **Lost Sounds**: **"The Contract"**—while Holly shook her head and laughed behind her clipboard—followed by the high-voltage synth-and-guitar duel of **"Steel and Synthetics"**.

And on the final crashing downbeat of *"Steel and Synthetics"*, the master lighting relay inside the stadium press box threw its main breaker switch.

All four towering stadium floodlight banks went completely dark.

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller's POV):** Read Act II (`20:25–20:55`) from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` as Jordan watches the `0–38` September 2014 scoreboard trauma permanently

> overwritten by **CPI 52 — VDU 0** in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 3: *Not Your Doll & Fifty-Two to Nothing*** • Explore the band's full cosmic archive at **stardust.raggiesoft.com**.

Part 4: Acts III & IV: Ad Astra, Cosmic Tidal Lock & Mile Marker 98

Date: 2016-05-21 at 20:55 America/New_York

8:55 PM — Act III: *"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"*

In the sudden, breathless blackness after *"Steel and Synthetics"*, the open-air bowl of **The Crucible** vanished beneath the real May stars of the Blue Ridge Mountains.

On the darkened stage deck, under dim blue work lights while his guitar tech swapped his standard sunburst electric guitar for his sustain-modified 1987 custom dual-humbucker guitar tuned for **Act III: *Cosmic Tidal Lock***, **Ryan** looked across the stage at **Cassidy**.

In twenty-one years since Cassidy had written her four-movement progressive rock autobiography in that unheated Blacksburg warehouse in 1995, **"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"**—commonly known to Stardust Engine fans simply as ***"Ad Astra"*** when referring to it informally—had never been performed at a live concert. It hadn't existed yet when they recorded 1990's *Live in Chicago*, and they had omitted it from the tighter two-hour waterfront amphitheater setlist of 2005's *Live in Norfolk*. Tonight, sequenced in true astrophysical launch order to open the ten-song **Twin Moons** live suite, was the definitive live concert debut of the most important piece of music his sister had ever created.

Nobody said a word into the microphones.

Out on the auxiliary riser, Claire Lindqvist stayed behind the main wraparound synthesizer rig while Cassidy walked out alone to the very center edge of the stage in the dark, holding a wireless handheld microphone in both hands.

A low sub-bass synthesizer drone and a lonely, haunting woodwind melody began to drift out across the silent turf—followed seconds later by Cassidy raising the microphone to her lips and singing a soaring, wordless operatic vocalise (*"Ahhhh-ahhh-ahhhhhh… Oooooh-ahhhhh-ahhhhhh…"*) that echoed off the upper decks into the mountain night.

From his chair on stage-left, Ryan heard a wave of stunned, electric murmurs ripple through sixty-five thousand fans across **The Crucible** as the entire stadium realized at once what song they were hearing—and wondered whether Cassidy was only singing a short sixty-second prelude or if the band was actually about to play the entire four-part epic live.

Then the gentle woodwind shattered into a blistering 16th-note analog synthesizer pulse and Tyler's driving double-kick drums.

Cold, stark white searchlights dropped straight down from the overhead lighting grid, boxing Cassidy in at the front lip of the stage like the glowing bars of a courtroom cage for ***Part I: The Cage***. Standing completely exposed at the edge of the stage without a keyboard in front of her, Cassidy tore into the opening verses

with raw, trembling intensity—remembering the 1992 New York federal courtroom where their trial counsel had been forced to detonate Holly's **1986 `$1.00` Cross-License** like a legal nuclear warhead, saving CPI's rights while burning the band's commercial catalog to ash:

> *"The Shark was right, the nuke went off! We won the battle, but at what cost?! We're radioactive, we're litigious! We're just the joke, the victim-saints! I'm trapped inside this Wilderness! This Fortress built on bitterness! This isn't freedom… this is a cell… This righteous hell…"*

As the heavy drums dropped away, Cassidy's voice softened to a quiet, aching confession in the dark (*"The fight is over, the dragon's slain / So why am I still in chains?"*) before a dark, pulsing bass sequencer began to throb through the stadium floor.

On the downbeat of ***Part II: Ignition (Ad Astra)***, the white searchlight cage snapped off and shattered outward into twin pillars of crimson and solar-gold light.

Ryan unlocked his brakes, wheeled his manual chair right up beside his sister at center stage, and kicked in his dual-stack tube overdrive—driving the climbing `11.2 km/s` guitar riff alongside Marcus Vance while Tyler, Doc Holloway, and Evan pushed the twin-engine rhythm section into a relentless vertical ascent:

> *"I'm climbing! Climbing! Past the point of no return! The engines screaming, watch the bridges burn! Pushing through the max-Q, the violent shake! Every single promise that I had to break! I'm reaching for the sky, I'm breaking the hold! A story that has never been told! Escape velocity! I'm finally free! Ad astra! (To the stars!) That's where I'll be!"*

After trading breathless, high-velocity guitar and synthesizer solos with Claire Lindqvist while the 120-foot screen behind them showed the horizon of the Earth curving away into the black of space, Ryan looked across the stage at Cassidy. Back in 1995 in the warehouse, he had leaned over his wheel and physically yanked the AC power plug out of the wall socket to create the sudden, violent silence of **Main Engine Cutoff (MECO)**. Tonight, wired into the stadium master relay switch at his pedalboard, Ryan held the screaming high note on the twentieth fret as Cassidy sang:

> *"I'm climbing! Climbing! Past the point of no return! I'm flying! Flying! With the fire I let burn! Just a signal, a distant light! Burning through the endless night! Ad astra! (To the stars!) Ad astra! Into the silent, endless night!"*

Ryan stomped his master kill-switch.

POP—KZZZZT—

Every amplifier, bass, and drum on stage cut to instantaneous, dead silence.

For one heartbeat, the vacuum of space hung over the stadium—and then sixty-five thousand people in the stands erupted into a deafening roar, half the crowd leaping to their feet cheering in the dark because they thought the band had just brought a six-minute concert arrangement of the song to a triumphant finish.

Out on the darkened stage, neither Cassidy nor Ryan moved an inch to take a bow. Holding his finger over the twelfth fret of his fretless bass, Evan waited for the wave of applause to crest, and then let a slow, floating fretless bass pulse and liquid, zero-gravity synthesizer pads swell underneath the cheering stadium to open ***Part III: The Cosmos***.

At that exact millisecond, the infrared DMX transmitters atop the press box fired.

Across all sixty-five thousand seats of **The Crucible**, every complementary LED wristband lit up at once—transforming the entire human bowl of the stadium into a living, breathing deep-space nebula of swirling crimson reds, sapphire blues, ultraviolet purples, and solar gold.

Even from the stage, looking out from the center of a sixty-five-thousand-star galaxy, Ryan felt his breath catch. Using his volume pedal and a handheld magnetic string sustainer so the attack of his pick completely disappeared, Ryan floated weightless, violin-like guitar swells beneath Cassidy's voice as she sang the cosmic chorus (*"I'm loved by the sun! I'm held by the void! / An orbit just begun! A life not destroyed!"*) before rising into the bridge that defined their 1986 origin:

> *"I see the colors of the nebula A place I've only seen in dreams The reds, the blues, the purples call Flowing in majestic streams… This is the place I was meant to be! This is the Stardust that is me! The cosmos and the rocket's fire! My one, my only true desire! Loved by the sun!"*

When the floating nebula pads finally gave way to a crisp, syncopated acoustic-and-electric groove for the triumphant splashdown of ***Part IV: Re-entry (The New World)***, the entire stadium surged back to life as Cassidy sang:

> *"The Cage is broken, the victim-saint is gone! A new clean script is in my head! The friction burned away in the fire! Leaving only my true desire! I'm not escaping anymore! I'm coming home to a brand new shore!"*

Stepping right up to the front edge of the stage, Cassidy held her microphone out with both hands toward the stands—and all sixty-five thousand Forgers raised their glowing wrists toward the stage and roared the four words back in a single, earth-shaking voice:

> **65,000 FORGERS: *"HELD BY THE SUN!"***

Riding a joyous, full-band stadium-rock outro (*"I'm held by the void! My orbit has begun! / A life is not destroyed! / Ad astra! Ad astra! Ad astra!"*), the entire nine-piece band slammed down together on a massive final chord.

As the final golden chord faded into the Appalachian night and the stadium shook with a minute-long standing ovation, Ryan watched Cassidy raise a hand to her heart, lower her forehead to her microphone, and whisper a breathless, overwhelmed:

> *"Thank you so much…"*

Twenty-six years ago at the Rosemont Horizon on *Live in Chicago*, she had whispered those exact four words at the end of *"If You Walked Away"* when she was twenty-four years old, exhausted to the point of collapse, and terrified of being abandoned. Tonight, at fifty, surrounded by sixty-five thousand people who loved her for exactly who she was, those same four words sounded like pure victory.

Without breaking the deep-space atmosphere, a canopy of cool indigo planetarium lasers fanned out overhead as the band glided upward through the two interlocking instrumental movements of **The Apoapsis Suite**—**"Apoapsis"** and **"Second Apoapsis"**—into the sweeping vocal horizon of **"The Spectrum (True Color)"** (*"And we are seeing the true spectrum! / A billion stars burning ultraviolet and blue"*) and the indigo planetarium calm of **"Moon 1: Tidal Lock"** (*"No matter how I turn, no matter where I fly / You are the only anchor in my sky / Yeah, I'm in a tidal lock with you!"*).

9:25 PM — Act IV: *Roche Limit & Mile Marker 98*

And then, as the last tranquil indigo synthesizer pad of Cassidy's *"Moon 1: Tidal Lock"* faded into the starfield, every indigo planetarium laser overhead flashed emergency crimson.

A low, urgent klaxon warning tone echoed across the stadium bowl as the **Engine Room Records Planetarium Narrator**'s voice cut through the dark:

> *"Warning: Gravitational anomaly detected. Secondary satellite has crossed the Roche limit. Structural failure imminent. Brace for impact."*

Ryan unlocked his brakes, rolled all the way out to the front-center edge of the stage deck, and kicked in the heaviest, most aggressive distortion channel on his rig for **Act IV: *Roche Limit & Mile Marker 98 (Moon 2 — Ryan's Heavy-Friction Orbit)***.

For the next twenty-five minutes, it was Ryan's turn to steer the ship.

Where Cassidy's *Moon 1* used the astrophysics of a tidal lock to celebrate unbreakable stability, Ryan used the **Roche limit**—the gravitational distance at which a moon is torn apart by tidal forces—to confront the night of December 10, 1990 head-on. Tearing through **"Moon 2: Roche Limit"** (*"We crossed the Roche Limit! / Tearing me apart, tearing me apart!"*) and straight into the visceral title cut of his 2003 concept album, **"Impact (Mile Marker 98)"**, Ryan leaned into his center microphone while the 120-foot screen behind him dissolved from a blinding Interstate 81 snowstorm into a high-velocity asteroid debris field:

> *"I was holding the controls, trying to beat the storm Trying to keep the Freighter steady, trying to keep it warm Running forty through the dark, the hazard beacons bright… We hit a massive fragment in the great unknown— A t Mile Marker 98, I lost the throne! We're barely alive, but we survived the night!"*

There was no self-pity in the way Ryan played it—only fifty-two-year-old muscle, calloused fingertips, and the roar of twin drum kits as Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler answered his distress beacon on **"Mayday: The Intercept"**. Then, over a rhythmic hospital heartbeat monitor and the calm voice of the Planetarium Narrator (*"Welcome back to the Engine Room Records Planetarium. Following the fragmentation event, the central engine has been salvaged and transported to the*

Star City Orbital Ward. Diagnostics indicate a complete and permanent severing of the T-10 power conduit. In the aftermath of a catastrophic impact, survival is no longer a matter of velocity, but of protocol…"), Ryan tore into the heavy, stomping hard-rock groove of **"Star City: Orbital Ward"**, translating his recovery at Star City General Hospital, his strict four-hour **Protocol T-10** clock, and Evan and Tyler's synchronized *"Freight Dog"* twin-lifts into an orbital rescue mission.

Finally, as the red warning lasers melted into warm golden sunlight and Cassidy stepped up beside his wheelchair for the closing sibling duet of **"Twin Moons: Touchdown"**, Ryan locked his distorted electric guitar into unison with her analog synth brass (*"The Engine and the Anchor locking into the groove / We finally found the gravity, we're ready to move! / Touchdown!"*), bringing both Twin Moons down out of the freezing vacuum of space and landing them safely on solid ground in Blacksburg as the Planetarium Narrator concluded:

> *"Atmospheric entry complete. Gravity is stable… The simulation is now concluded. Please exit safely, and welcome home."*

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller's POV):** Read Acts III & IV (`20:55–21:50`) from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` as 65,000 wristbands turn the stadium bowl into a living deep-space nebula for *"Escape Velocity (Ad Astra)"* and *"Mile Marker 98"* in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 4: *Escape Velocity (Ad Astra), Tidal Lock & Mile Marker 98*** • Explore the band's full cosmic archive at `stardust.raggiesoft.com`.

Part 5: Act V: Our Own Frequency, Brother's Keeper & The Summer Festival

Date: 2016-05-21 at 21:50 America/New_York

9:50 PM — Act V: *Our Own Frequency* & *"Brother's Keeper"*

As the final chord of *"Twin Moons: Touchdown"* faded out and the Planetarium Narrator welcomed the stadium back to Earth's gravity, **Evan** unstrapped his bass, **Tyler** stepped down from the drum riser, and the twins—followed by all five members of the **Orbital Crew**—walked over to center stage, wrapped **Ryan** and **Cassidy** in a long, tight hug, and walked off into the stage-left wings.

The towering stadium lighting rigs dimmed all the way down until only two warm, amber living-room spotlights shone at the center of the stage deck: Cassidy seated on the bench of her gleaming black acoustic grand piano, and Ryan rolling his manual wheelchair right up flush against the left side of her piano bench—hip-to-hip and shoulder-to-shoulder—before clicking both of his wheel locks shut.

His guitar tech handed him his acoustic cedar-top dreadnought and quietly stepped offstage.

For the first time all night, there were no drum kits, no synthesizer stacks, and no hundred-watt tube amplifiers. Just a brother and a sister sitting together in the middle of a sixty-five-thousand-seat stadium as if they were back in their living room on **Progress Street**.

“Evan and Tyler are gonna take five backstage for a little bit,” Cassidy said softly into her piano microphone, her voice carrying across a stadium so hushed you could hear the May breeze rustling the flags atop the press box. “Back in two thousand and eight, right in the middle of our ten-year hiatus, Ryan and I couldn’t face the cameras or the stadiums anymore. So we locked the front door of our house right down the road on Progress Street, sat down in the living room with just an acoustic guitar, a piano, and two microphones, and recorded an album we never toured.”

“We just uploaded it on a Tuesday morning with one sentence: *‘We’re still here, and we’re okay,*”” Ryan added into his boom mic, smiling out at the quiet dark. “We never thought we’d play these songs in a stadium… but tonight, sixty-five thousand of you feel just like our living room.”

Sitting shoulder-to-shoulder with his sister, Ryan fingerpicked the warm, intimate acoustic intro of **“Our Own Frequency”** (*“Just the piano and the six-string strum / Before the noise and the kingdom come / No one to tell us how the story ends / Just a brother and a sister and the time we spend / On our own frequency / Just you and me”*), their voices blending in the effortless sibling harmony they had shared since they were children.

When the final acoustic harmonic faded into pin-drop silence, Ryan rested his forearm along the curve of his acoustic guitar and looked up at the sixty-five thousand people sitting in the dark around them. His heart beat a steady, honest `76 BPM` against his ribs.

“Earlier in *Star City: Orbital Ward*, we sang about the four-hour clock and the maintenance protocols in sci-fi metaphors,” Ryan said softly, his voice echoing clearly off the quiet limestone stands. “This next song is the centerpiece of **Our Own Frequency**, and it’s the most private song Cassidy and I have ever written—without any metaphors at all. People look up at a stage and see two hours of lights and guitars. They don’t see what T-ten paralysis actually takes behind closed doors. They don’t see Cassidy and Evan and Tyler helping me through my daily care and toileting routines, or stretching my legs every morning so they don’t atrophy. They don’t see how we push the bed against the wall at night so I can sleep on the inside, and my sister sleeps on the outside edge as a human bed rail so I don’t roll off in the dark.”

Across the stadium, not a single person made a sound. Down in `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`, Ryan could see the young man in the manual wheelchair leaning forward with his hands resting on his handrims, listening intently while his friends stood close around his chair.

Beside Ryan on the piano bench, Cassidy smiled tenderly through her glasses and spoke into her mic:

“And they don’t see how you keep me anchored when the world gets too loud for my head to handle. We take care of each other. That’s what family does.”

Ryan took a slow breath.

“Doing all of those daily routines on tour buses and in hotel rooms across the world was one thing when I was twenty-six in nineteen-ninety,” Ryan continued, his voice honest and steady. “Twenty-six years later… I’m gonna be honest with you, Forger

Nation. Accommodating this chair on the road has gotten too hard on my body, and on my family. Tonight is the final stop of the *Reignition* tour… and tonight is the last concert a touring Stardust Engine will ever play."

An audible, collective gasp rippled across sixty-five thousand people inside **The Crucible**, followed by a warm, deeply respectful wave of supportive applause rising from the turf.

Instantly, Cassidy leaned forward into her piano microphone, her eyes sparkling behind her glasses:

"Wait—don't be sad! We aren't retiring!" Cassidy called out over the murmur. "If touring the world is too hard on Ryan, then the world can come to Blacksburg! To give the **Town of Blacksburg** and **CPI** time to build this right, starting in **August 2017**, we're launching the annual **Forger Nation Summer Festival**! A massive CPI Open House for incoming and prospective freshmen, the biggest downtown Blacksburg block party of the summer with stages for signed and unsigned bands, and every single year we'll close the festival right here inside **The Crucible** with fireworks—and sleep in our own beds on Progress Street every night!"

For ten full seconds, a thunderous roar of relief and joy erupted across the stadium as the 120-foot curved LED screen behind the piano illuminated in warm gold lettering:

```
THE FORGER NATION SUMMER FESTIVAL
CPI OPEN HOUSE • DOWNTOWN BLACKSBURG BLOCK PARTY • THE CRUCIBLE
RESIDENCY
INAUGURAL WEEKEND: AUGUST 2017
```

As the cheers gently hushed back to pin-drop silence, Ryan whispered into his microphone, *"This is 'Brother's Keeper,'"* and Cassidy's fingers began the delicate, melancholy grand-piano intro of **"Brother's Keeper"**, joined seconds later by Ryan's steady, comforting fingerpicked acoustic guitar:

> *"They look at the chair and they think it's weak They whisper their pity whenever we speak But they don't see the mornings, the stretches and pain Th e quiet routines keeping us sane Sleeping on the edge, a human bed rail Catc hing the other whenever we fail…"*

One by one across the darkened stadium, sixty-five thousand fans raised quiet white phone lights into the air—not the programmed computer wristbands, just sixty-five thousand human hands holding up a warm sea of candlelight while Ryan and Cassidy harmonized on the chorus (*"We trade all the armor, we trade all the scars / We built our own world underneath all the stars / When the body won't work, we become our own feet / When the pressure is heavy, we make it retreat"*), flowing directly into 2008's **"Safe Person"**.

As the final chord of *"Safe Person"* lingered in the quiet night air, Cassidy smiled across the piano at Ryan.

"On *Reignition*, we recorded the sequel to *'Safe Person'* with the full stadium band," Cassidy told the crowd softly, "but since we're still sitting here in our living room with you guys, Ryan and I wanted to strip this one all the way down to just the piano and the six-string."

Without a single drum or electric amplifier, brother and sister sang the stripped-down acoustic grand-piano and fingerpicked guitar rendition of 2015's **"Still Your Safe Person"**:

> *"When the static hits a hundred and the room begins to spin I am still your safe person—let the quiet in! Put your headphones on or lean against my shoulder tight I will hold the perimeter throughout the longest night!"*

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller's POV):** Read Act V (`21:50–22:15`) from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` as Jordan listens to Ryan's speech before *"Brother's Keeper"* and taps `*"That song is us."*` in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 5: *Our Own Frequency, Brother's Keeper & The Summer Festival Announcement***
> • Explore the band's full cosmic archive at **`stardust.raggiesoft.com`**.

Part 6: Act VI: Neon on the Huckleberry Trail & Saturday Night Lights

Date: 2016-05-21 at 22:15 America/New_York

10:15 PM — Act VI: *Saturday Night Lights* & *Progress Street*

When **Evan**, **Tyler**, and the **Orbital Crew** walked back out onto the stage deck at `22:15` to open **Act VI: *The Homecoming Sprint***, Ryan swapped his acoustic guitar back for his sunburst electric guitar.

Because 1989's *"If You Walked Away"* had been permanently banned from every Stardust Engine setlist after the 1990 crash to protect Cassidy from autistic sensory and abandonment overload, they opened the full-band electric return with 1997's **"Echoes in the Wire"**.

And the instant *"Echoes in the Wire"* ended, all four massive **Ironstone** stadium floodlight towers high above the east and west rims blazed back on at one hundred percent power—bathing the turf and the stands in the unmistakable, electric daylight of a fourth-quarter Saturday night in Blacksburg as Ryan wheeled to the front of the stage and struck a ringing stadium guitar chord.

"Back in two thousand and four," Ryan shouted into his microphone as sixty-five thousand fans leaped to their feet and roared at the sudden stadium floodlights, "we gave this next track to the university to play over the stadium speakers between the third and fourth quarters! We made a promise twelve years ago that we would **never** play this song live at a concert unless we were standing right here inside **The Crucible**! Blacksburg—welcome to the fourth quarter!"

"Hold those four fingers up, Forger Nation!" Cassidy shouted, raising four fingers toward the night sky. "Let's light up the mountains!"

The entire stadium turned into a fourth-quarter pep rally for the live concert debut of **"Saturday Night Lights: The Crucible"** as sixty-five thousand people jumped in unison (`"GO FORGERS! GO CPI!"`), rolling straight into **"Progress Street: Where the Fire Began"**.

10:24 PM — *"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"* (*"Huckleberry Trail"*)

As the final chord of *"Progress Street"* rang out, Marcus Vance handed Ryan his shimmering twelve-string electric guitar.

Ryan looked over at Cassidy at center stage and gave her a quiet nod. Neither of them said a word into their microphones. They didn't introduce the song, and they didn't explain it.

Instead, Ryan simply struck the opening chorused twelve-string arpeggio of **"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"**—known to locals and Forgers simply as ***"Huckleberry Trail"***—and Cassidy's warm analog synth bells chimed in at `124 BPM`.

From center stage, Ryan watched an unforgettable reaction ripple across **The Crucible**.

For the first two bars, all sixty-five thousand people in the stadium were in **stunned disbelief** that The Stardust Engine was playing something so hyperlocal at a live stadium concert without even announcing it. Right down at the front terrace railing of `Section 104, Row A`, Ryan could see students and alumni grabbing their partners' arms with wide eyes, mouthing the exact same words that scattered pockets of CPI alumni had shouted in arenas across the country: *"Wait—no way! Are they seriously playing 'Huckleberry Trail' right now?!"*

When they had put *"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"* on *Reignition* the year before, Ryan and Cassidy had written it as a quiet, unassuming thank-you note to their neighbors for letting them have ten years of peace on the six-mile paved rail-trail between the **Pendleton Library** lawn and Christiansburg. All across the *Reignition* Tour—in Chicago, Los Angeles, London, or Toronto—ninety-nine percent of the arena crowds had swayed and clapped politely without having any idea what a "Huckleberry Trail" was.

Inside **The Crucible**, the instant the initial shock of recognition passed and Evan's bassline and Tyler's drums kicked in beneath the 120-foot curved LED screen's projection of an autumn sunset over the narrow asphalt rail-trail, disbelief turned into a thunderous roar of hometown pride as sixty-five thousand people started cheering them on!

The one percent of out-of-town fans who had driven into Blacksburg just for the concert looked around their sections in bewildered amazement, wondering what on earth was going on and why an unannounced deep cut about a local bike path was suddenly shaking the concrete deck like the biggest anthem of the night—while to the sixty-five thousand **Forgers** and Montgomery County residents in attendance, **it was HOME**.

The second Cassidy sang the closing lines of the first verse—*"Six miles of asphalt from the library lawn / Where the old Huckleberry train used to roll on"*—a massive, emotional cheer surged up not only from the twenty-year-old undergrads in **The Anvil**, who jogged and biked that paved six-mile trail past the cattle pastures and Price Mountain every afternoon, but from the lifelong New River Valley families in the lower bowl—including eighty-year-old **Walter *"Santa Walt"* Pendleton** (`CPI Class of 1956`), the locally famous real-bearded **New River Valley Mall** Santa standing right at the `Section 104, Row A` railing in his maroon

flat cap and cream `1956` cardigan, wiping joyful tears from his cheek with his handkerchief as he remembered riding the actual **Huckleberry Train** between Christiansburg's Cambria Depot and Blacksburg before its final whistle in 1958.

By the time the second pre-chorus built toward the drum fill, something happened that **nobody on stage had planned or rehearsed**.

During soundcheck that afternoon, Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler had simply expected to play *"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"* straight through as a warm, breezy album track between *"Progress Street"* and *"Neon Hearts"*. They had never planned a crowd singalong break for a deep cut, and there was no cue on the monitor script.

Instead, **the audience made the decision for them**.

Sixty-five thousand people across the lower bowl, **The Anvil**, and the upper decks were already singing so loudly over the pre-chorus that their voices completely overpowered the stage wedges and the in-ear monitors. Up on the drum riser, Tyler looked over at Evan with a huge, stunned grin; Cassidy stopped mid-breath with tears shining behind her glasses, realizing there was no point trying to sing over sixty-five thousand people claiming their own hometown song; and Ryan just went with the flow, leaning into his boom mic and screaming at the top of his lungs:

"Take it, Forger Nation! It's yours!"

Both of them stepped back from their microphones completely—Ryan just chiming the twelve-string chords from his wheelchair and Cassidy pressing her right hand over her heart while sixty-five thousand voices across three generations of Blacksburg and Christiansburg history carried the entire chorus across the dark valley under the shimmering autumn-gold stadium floodlight towers:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"CHASING THE NEON ON THE HUCKLEBERRY TRAIL! WHERE THE TWILIGHT GLOWS AND THE SHADOWS SAIL! SPINNING OUR WHEELS THROUGH THE GOLDEN LEAVES UNDERNEATH A SKY THAT STILL BELIEVES! SEE THE STADIUM TOWERS FLICKER ON IN THE NIGHT PAINTING THE VALLEY IN ELECTRIC LIGHT! EVERY AUTUMN EVENING TELLS THE SAME OLD TALE WE'RE HOME TOGETHER ON THE HUCKLEBERRY TRAIL!"***

10:29 PM — *Neon Hearts*, *My Anchor Holds* & The False Ending

Trading their grinning sign-off (*"Race you back to Progress Street!"* / *"You're on, Cass!"*) to a deafening hometown ovation, the band sprinted straight into the 1980s arena-rock punch of 1989's **"Neon Hearts"**.

When Cassidy's warm grand piano intro opened 1987's **"My Anchor Holds"** under candlelight-gold and starlight-white beams, Ryan glanced out toward `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` while playing the soaring guitar melody. There at the terrace railing, the blonde young woman stood directly behind the young man's wheelchair in his Foundry Maroon `CPI` shirt with her arms wrapped warmly around his chest and her chin resting on his shoulder, swaying with their friends as sixty-five thousand voices sang the chorus back to the stage.

Then, with Ryan's spoken grin (*"Good morning, Forger Nation"*) and Cassidy's shout (*"The switches are back on! Let's go!"*), the band unleashed one more explosive burst of fireworks on the comeback anthem **"Reignition: Lights Up on Progress Street"** before slowing the tempo down at `22:35` for what everyone in the stadium believed was the final song of the night: 2004's **"Last Bus Home: Lights Out on Progress Street"**.

One by one, the stage lights dimmed until only a single porch-light amber spot remained over Cassidy's piano and Ryan's chair. As the drums and bass faded to a lone upright piano chord, Cassidy leaned into her mic:

"Lights out on Progress Street…"

Ryan reached back toward the main toggle switch on his amplifier rack.

"Goodnight, Forger Nation," Ryan said softly into his microphone. "We love you."

He flipped the switch down with an audible *CLICK*, and every stage light, floodlight tower, and Jumbotron screen inside **The Crucible** cut to pitch black.

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller's POV):** Read Act VI (`22:15–22:40`) from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` as the unannounced opening chords of *"Neon on the Huckleberry Trail"* send sixty-five thousand Forgers from stunned disbelief into roaring hometown pride and Jordan sways in Aubrie Jean's arms during their wedding processional song *"My Anchor Holds"* in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 6: *Neon on the Huckleberry Trail, Saturday Night Lights & My Anchor Holds*** • Explore the band's full cosmic archive at `stardust.raggiesoft.com`.

Part 7: Act VII: Electric Color & Lights Out on Progress Street

Date: 2016-05-21 at 22:40 America/New_York

10:40 PM — Operation Anvil & The `1:40` Reveal of *"Electric Color"*

Sitting in the pitch dark at center-left stage while sixty-five thousand people cheered into the blackness—and while a few thousand fans in the upper decks began reaching under their seats for their jackets, convinced that *"Lights Out on Progress Street"* was the literal end of the concert—**Ryan O'Connell** kept his right palm resting silently over the strings of his cherry-sunburst electric guitar and listened.

Beneath the roar of the crowd, he could feel three hundred pairs of rubber-soled marching shoes moving silently up the stage-left and stage-right field ramps in total darkness.

Not a single brass player bumped a bell. Not a single snare drummer clicked a stick. Practicing the exact silent deployment they had rehearsed all semester for **Operation Anvil**, all three hundred members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** took their positions in tiered arcs across the back and wings of the stage behind Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and the Orbital Crew.

After ninety seconds of darkness, **Cassidy** pressed a single, warm, sustained chord on her grand piano.

A lone white spotlight bloomed over her at center stage. Across the stadium, people who had stepped into the aisles froze in their tracks and turned back toward the stage as Cassidy looked up at the sixty-five thousand faces rising into the Blacksburg sky:

> *"Blacksburg! We've been all over the world… but there is no better feeling… Than ending this entire tour… right here at home, in the Crucible! Are you with us one last time Forger Nation? Let's go!"*

At `0:23`, every bank of stadium floodlights blasted on in blinding white and gold as Ryan, Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler fused with all three hundred members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** to unleash the towering, seventy-seven-second **1980s Album-Oriented Rock (AOR)** guitar-and-300-horn brass overture that Cassidy had disguised all semester in the Marching Forgers' folders as ***'Exercise 87-B: The Anvil Finale'***.

It was one of the most fun seventy-seven seconds of Ryan's entire life.

Because the roaring, full-throttle 1980s stadium-rock guitar fanfare—complete with a dramatic false start, choppy tension-building syncopations, blistering twin-lead arena-rock guitars, and a three-hundred-piece collegiate brass counter-melody—sounded nothing like the glossy 1987 synth-pop radio single that Apex Records had manufactured when they stripped out Ryan's rock guitars and replaced Tyler's drums with a drum machine, nobody in the building had any idea what song they were playing. Ryan could look right out across the front rows and `Section 104, Row A` and watch sixty-five thousand die-hard fans grinning in total bewilderment—leaning over to their friends and shouting *"What song is this?! Is it a brand-new song?!"*

Forty seconds passed. Then sixty seconds. Then seventy-five seconds, as Ryan climbed the fretboard in a screaming dual-lead harmony with Marcus Vance and all three hundred Marching Forgers hit a colossal, stadium-shaking brass crescendo—

And at **`1:40` on the dot**, every guitar, synthesizer, and horn on the stage cut out completely.

In the sudden silence of the sixty-five-thousand-seat fortress, only Tyler's isolated, chest-rattling kick drum kept pounding (*BOOM... BOOM... BOOM...*).

Stepping up to her microphone at the front edge of the stage, Cassidy smiled out at sixty-five thousand people and sang the first four lines:

> *"Woke up this morning, the world was gray Didn't know the colors had all faded away Been living in a room with the curtains drawn tight Then you flipped a switch and turned on the light"*

The sound of sixty-five thousand people realizing at the exact same second that they were listening to **"Electric Color"**—reclaimed at last as a full-throttle **1980s Stadium Rock** anthem—was the single loudest human sound Ryan O'Connell had ever heard on Planet Earth.

Suddenly, even Tyler's kick drum dropped out completely, leaving Cassidy's soaring voice completely unaccompanied against the roar of sixty-five thousand people across the dark valley:

> *"The city sounds were just a buzz in my ear A static station I could never quite hear But now the noise is turning into a song And I finally feel like I belong"*

And when the full 1980s Arena Rock band and all three hundred **CPI Marching Forgers** slammed in together on the chorus at maximum power, the DMX transmitters fired the final command of the night.

Across all sixty-five thousand seats of **The Crucible**, every LED wristband exploded into a sweeping, thirty-tier rainbow wave of electric cyan, magenta, solar gold, emerald green, and ultraviolet purple—while Ryan's overdriven electric guitar, Cassidy's soaring vocals, Evan and Tyler's thunderous rhythm section, and three hundred CPI Marching Forgers shook the Gothic limestone walls to their foundations:

> *"Oh, I'm seeing in electric color Finding a rhythm I never knew Dancing in a brand new summer My whole world feels bright and new It's an electric-colored feeling And it all started with you!"*

After Evan's heavy bass groove drove through the bridge, the music cut out completely to a deafening stadium roar at `2:53`. Looking out across her alma mater, Cassidy's voice rang off the Ironstone walls:

> *"Can you feel that, CPI? That's the sound of a new world. No more gray. Just ... color. Here comes the solo!"*

Rolling right up to the front edge of the stage at `3:07`, Ryan unleashed a massive, screaming stadium guitar solo from his wheelchair that handed off seamlessly into Cassidy's sweeping analog synthesizer solo before Cassidy called out, *"Sing it with me Blacksburg! One last time!"*

When the band stripped the instrumentation back down to Tyler's isolated kick drum at `4:05`, Cassidy held her microphone out toward the stands:

> *"Just you! Let me hear you sing it!"* **65,000 FORGERS: *"Oh-oh-oh! Electric Color!"*** *"I can't hear you! For the end of the tour!"* **65,000 FORGERS: *"Oh-oh-oh! Electric Color!"***

Looking out across the fifty-yard line toward `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`, Ryan saw the young man in the manual wheelchair with both hands raised high into the glowing rainbow air, laughing through happy tears behind his rectangular glasses while his blonde partner and his friends linked arms around his chair.

Cassidy roared **`"COME ON!"`**—and the full rock band fused with all three hundred members of the **CPI Marching Forgers** in a colossal brass-section swell, drumline explosion, rainbow confetti cannons, and fifty-foot golden Roman candles as sixty-five thousand voices belted the final chorus into the Appalachian night:

> **65,000 FORGERS:** ***"OH, I'M SEEING IN ELECTRIC COLOR FINDING A RHYTHM I NEVER KNEW DANCING IN A BRAND NEW SUMMER MY WHOLE WORLD FEELS BRIGHT AND NEW IT'S AN ELECTRIC-COLORED FEELING AND IT ALL STARTED WITH YOU!"***

Yeah, Ryan thought, hitting the final sustained stadium power chord alongside three hundred blaring horns and a heavy gong strike. *That's why we never gave up.*

As the five-minute-and-twenty-six-second chord echoed across the valley under a sky full of maroon, orange, and rainbow fireworks, Cassidy's voice rang out over the cheering stadium one final time:

> *"Thank you Forger Nation! Thank you Blacksburg! We love you! We're home! Goodnight!"*

11:15 PM — The Crucible Bus Loop & Lights Out on Progress Street

When the final five-minute-and-twenty-six-second chord of *"Electric Color"* crashed to a halt under a sky full of maroon, orange, and rainbow fireworks, **Ryan**, **Cassidy**, **Evan**, and **Tyler** linked arms with Dr. Arthur Vance, Sarah Jenkins, and the **Orbital Crew** at the front lip of the stage for one final bow before sixty-five thousand screaming alumni and students.

Rolling down the stage-left hydraulic ramp into the South End Zone tunnel two minutes later, Ryan barely had time to set his brake before **Holly** threw both arms around his neck—her immaculate maroon blazer covered in rainbow mylar confetti and her eyes shining with tears.

"Zero leaks, three hundred thousand dollars wired to the student escrow at midnight, and the best three hours of music you four have ever played in your lives," Holly whispered fiercely against his cheek before hugging Cassidy, Evan, and Tyler. "Welcome home, Class of '89."

Thirty minutes later, after Ryan had changed into a dry maroon CPI hoodie and Evan had secured their guitars in the rear acoustic lounge of the family's **2015 Prairie Coachworks RLFD30**—the thirty-foot Restyled Low-Floor executive shuttle coach they had purchased in 2015 to succeed their beloved 2004 Launch Customer `#001` shuttle immortalized on the album cover of ***Progress Street***—Tyler took the CDL driver's seat, released the air brakes, and eased the coach quietly out of the South End Zone service gate onto Beamer Way.

With its amber LED destination sign dimmed to **`OUT OF SERVICE // PROGRESS STREET`** and its Obsidian Midnight and Cosmic Nebula livery blending into the night, the thirty-foot low-floor coach paused at the crosswalk beside the **Crucible Bus Loop**. From his locked wheelchair securement bay behind the front passenger window, Ryan looked out at the fleet of white-and-maroon sixty-foot articulated **Blue Ridge Transit** buses—built by the very same **Prairie Coachworks** factory in Winnipeg—staged nose-to-tail along the curb, their amber LED destination signs flashing **`CBURG TRANS CTR`** and **`GO FORGERS!`** in alternating letters.

Right at the front bay of the lead articulated shuttle, under the warm amber streetlamps, Ryan spotted the same young man in the manual wheelchair from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`—laughing with the transit supervisor in the high-

visibility vest before smoothly spinning his chair 180 degrees and backing up the low-floor front ramp in reverse with two effortless, confident pulls on his handrims, followed closely by his blonde partner and his three friends.

“Hey, Cass,” Ryan said softly, touching his sister’s arm in the forward lounge seat beside his wheelchair bay and nodding toward the bus window. “Look who’s on the lead shuttle. That’s the kid from `Section 104, Row A`—the one we passed on the Huckleberry Trail.”

Cassidy smiled warmly as the sixty-foot articulated bus knelt, retracted its front ramp, and pulled smoothly out into the night. “Look at that reverse ramp climb. He handles his chair almost as well as you do, big brother.”

“I never did get his name,” Ryan mused, watching the amber taillights of the Blue Ridge Transit shuttle turn out of the loop. “One of these days, I’d really like to meet him. Just to sit down and talk with another wheelchair user around here.”

Six minutes later, Tyler turned the thirty-foot **Prairie Coachworks** shuttle onto the quiet, tree-lined pavement of **Progress Street NE**, pulled alongside the curb in front of the house they had refused `$150,000,000` to leave, and knelt the front air suspension with a gentle hiss—deploying the front-door flip-out aluminum ADA ramp directly onto their own sidewalk in five seconds flat.

There was no tour bus waiting at the curb to haul them to another city at two in the morning. There was no airport tarmac, no strange hotel bathroom, and no alarm clock set for a soundcheck five hundred miles away.

By `23:45`, after completing his final midnight **Protocol T-10** check and stretching his legs with Cassidy and the twins, Ryan transferred onto the inside half of the wide mattress pushed flush against the bedroom wall.

Cassidy clicked off the bedside lamp, climbed onto the outside edge of the mattress—taking her lifelong post as her brother’s **human bed-rail**—and reached across the quilt to rest her hand over his.

“Goodnight, Ry,” she whispered in the dark.

Listening to the crickets outside the open bedroom window on **Progress Street**, Ryan closed his eyes and smiled.

“Goodnight, Cass. We’re home.”

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller’s POV):** Read Act VII (`22:40–23:30`) from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1` as Jordan and his friends try to guess the 77-second overture before the `1:40` reveal of *“Electric Color”* and board the Blue Ridge Transit articulated shuttle at the Crucible Bus Loop in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 7: *Electric Color (Live at the Crucible) & The Ride Home*** • Explore the band’s full cosmic archive at **`stardust.raggiesoft.com`**.

Part 8: The Morning After: 95.5°F at the Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center

Date: 2016-05-22 at 14:00 America/New_York

Sunday, May 22, 2016 • 2:00 PM — The Morning After *Live at the Crucible*

On any other world tour between 1987 and 2005, the Sunday afternoon after athree-hour stadium show meant waking up stiff and exhausted in a hotel bed four hundred miles away, transferring onto a cold shower bench in an unfamiliar bathroom, and spending four hours on an interstate highway before the next arena load-in.

On **Sunday, May 22, 2016**, **Ryan O'Connell** woke up in his own bed on **Progress Street NE** to the smell of **Evan** making buttermilk pancakes in the kitchen and the sound of Blacksburg songbirds outside the window.

Even so, playing thirty-four songs across three hours from a manual wheelchair the night before had left every muscle in Ryan's triceps, shoulders, latissimus dorsi, and lower back aching with deep post-concert fatigue.

"Come on, big brother," **Cassidy** said at `13:30`, holding up five swim bags with their blue plastic **`$30.00/month` Town of Christiansburg Non-Resident** barcode keytags clipped to the zippers. "You gave sixty-five thousand people everything in your tank last night. Today belongs to **The Cove**."

At `14:00`, after scanning their five non-resident keytags at the front counter of the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center** off **Mill Lane NE** in **Christiansburg** and changing in the private accessible **Family Changing Suites**, Ryan transferred out of his matte-black titanium everyday wheelchair onto one of the facility's white waterproof PVC transfer chairs.

As Cassidy pushed his waterproof transfer chair through the glass doors into the warm, humid alcove of **The Cove**—the facility's **`95.5°F`** warm-water therapy pool—Ryan noticed another dry custom titanium manual wheelchair (`a fourteen-pound Vanguard AeroLite-Ti` with a small brushed-silver nameplate on the crossbar reading **`SHUTTLECRAFT GALILEO`**) parked neatly against the tiled wall right next to where Evan parked Ryan's dry titanium chair.

And down in the steaming `95.5°F` water along the north hydrotherapy bench, surrounded by a close-knit group of college friends, was the exact young man from `Section 104, Row A, Seat 1`—and from `5:30 PM` on the **Huckleberry Trail** back in October 2014.

With his rectangular polycarbonate glasses held in place by a black neoprene sport strap, the young man was floating weightlessly in the `95.5°F` water while two young women—the blonde woman who had held him during *"My Anchor Holds"* last night (**Aubrie Jean**) and their tall blonde friend (**Madison**)—gently supported his hips and shoulders in the warm buoyancy, slowly guiding his legs through a careful series of range-of-motion stretches to ease his post-concert muscle tone.

Ryan didn't say a word at first. Rolling down the zero-depth ramp into the `95.5°F` water, he let Cassidy, Evan, Tyler, and Holly ease him off the PVC transfer chair and spend ten quiet minutes stretching his own legs and working the three-hour guitar-strap knots out of his shoulders in the warm hydrotherapy jets.

Watching the two groups across the thirty-foot therapy pool, Ryan felt a quiet pull in his chest.

From the outside, people always assumed that being a famous rock star meant you could talk to anyone in the world. In truth, fame was deeply isolating, and living in a wheelchair inside fame was doubly isolating. For twenty-six years since the December 10, 1990 crash on Interstate 81 had left him with a complete T10 spinal cord injury, almost everyone Ryan met outside his own family fell into one of two exhausting categories: fans and industry executives who either wanted something from him or walked on eggshells around his chair, or doctors and physical therapists who interacted with him clinically. Almost never did Ryan get to simply talk to another regular guy in a manual wheelchair in his own town—someone who didn't want an autograph or a favor, and who understood the unspoken daily reality of life on wheels in Blacksburg without a single word of explanation.

Here, thirty feet away in `95.5°F` municipal water, were two families doing the exact same unglamorous, loving physical work so two manual wheelchair users could live without pain.

2:25 PM — Roommate Fluency

Once Cassidy and Evan finished stretching his legs and Ryan was floating comfortably along the submerged stainless-steel handrail, Ryan looked across the warm water and caught the young man's eye.

Ryan drifted smoothly along the handrail until he was six feet away, with Cassidy, Holly, Evan, and Tyler floating right behind him.

"Hey, man—sorry to interrupt your stretch," Ryan said politely in a low, conversational voice, speaking directly to the young man. "Were you sitting right in the front row of `Section 104` at **The Crucible** last night… and wait a second, were you the guy in the manual chair who waved to us on the **Huckleberry Trail** back in October at five-thirty?"

Behind his water-spotted glasses, the young man's eyes went wide with pure, unguarded shock—the unmistakable look of a college student who had been watching Ryan command a sixty-five-thousand-seat stadium less than eighteen hours ago and couldn't quite believe that Ryan O'Connell was floating in a municipal therapy pool in Christiansburg asking to get to know *him*.

Ryan noticed the young man's mouth open slightly, saw the involuntary tension catch in his jaw and throat, and saw his eyes dart helplessly toward the dry changing-room corridor—unable to speak a word out loud and suddenly unsure what to do.

Before a single second of embarrassment could settle over him, the blonde woman at his left shoulder (**Aubrie Jean**) and the tall blonde woman at his right (**Madison**) moved with a quiet, practiced grace that Ryan recognized in his bones.

Feeling two quick taps of the young man's fingers against her underwater forearm and checking his eyes first for permission, the blonde woman smiled warmly at Ryan and Cassidy.

"He's saying a huge *yes* to both," she said gently. "This is my fiancé, **Jordan**. I'm **Aubrie Jean**, this is **Madison**—the three of us have been roommates in Bennett Hall since freshman year—and these are our family, **Mark**, **Zoë**, **Lauren**, **Hannah**, **Sarah**, **Jessica**, and **Isabel**. Jordan's cerebral palsy makes speaking out loud really tough, so he uses an AAC tablet for his voice, and we had to lock it in the dry locker so the pool water wouldn't fry the electronics."

Beside Ryan in the warm water, Cassidy let out a soft, deeply moved breath, her eyes shining behind her fogged lenses. For thirty years, whenever autistic sensory overload or a crowded press room made Cassidy's own words lock up in her throat, Ryan had stood at her shoulder and done the exact same thing Aubrie Jean and Madison were doing for Jordan right now.

"You never have to apologize for that around us, Jordan," Ryan said immediately, reaching his right hand across the surface of the `95.5°F` water. "I'm Ryan, these are my sisters Cass and Holly, and our twin cousins Evan and Tyler. It is really, really good to finally meet you, man. Just point, nod, or let Aubrie Jean and Madison translate—we speak roommate fluently in this family."

The tension melted right out of Jordan's shoulders. Smiling from ear to ear, Jordan shook Ryan's hand firmly—and then lifted his right hand out of the water and tapped two fingers to his temple in the exact fellow-wheelchair-user salute he had given Ryan on the **Huckleberry Trail** in October 2014, before tapping his chest and making a series of expressive hand gestures toward Mark and the trail.

Without missing a beat, **Madison** watched Jordan's hands and eyes and translated with a warm grin, glancing at Jordan as he nodded eagerly:

"He's saying that back in October 2014 when we passed you guys on the Huckleberry Trail, he had zero clue who **The Stardust Engine** was! He grew up in a house where he wasn't allowed to listen to music, so when Mark whispered your names on the trail, it meant nothing to him—he was just happy to see another guy in a manual chair out on the path!"

"And now he's tapping my arm to add the second part," **Aubrie Jean** laughed softly, reading Jordan's quick hand sign. "Three months after that walk on the trail, in January 2015, Zoë's dad **Daniel** put the 1987 vinyl LP of *Electric Color* on his turntable in Christiansburg—and the second Daniel said your names, Jordan realized you were the siblings and cousins from the Huckleberry Trail!"

Ryan threw his head back and laughed out loud, splashing the warm water with his palm while Evan, Tyler, and Holly grinned from ear to ear.

"Are you serious?!" Ryan said, looking at Jordan with a huge grin. "Man, you have no idea how much I love hearing that! Because I'll tell you a secret, Jordan: that October evening at five-thirty when you and your friends walked past us in your CPI hoodies by the cattle pastures? When you looked over at my chair and just gave me a regular neighbor's wave without anybody pulling out a camera or treating us like a circus act—that exact moment was why Cass stopped us under the maple tree five minutes later and sang the opening lines of ***'Neon on the Huckleberry Trail'***!"

Jordan's eyes went wide behind his glasses, pointing a finger at himself and his friends in amazement.

"You guys!" Cassidy beamed, nodding enthusiastically beside Ryan. "When I sang *'October five-thirty and the air turns crisp'* and *'Students in their hoodies jogging two by two / Nodding with a smile as we roll on through / No autographs asked, just a neighbor's wave'*—that was literally you and your family! That's why Ryan recognized you on the camera monitor in `Section 104, Row A` before the show last night!"

Ryan looked at the wide, amazed expression in Jordan's eyes behind his water-spotted lenses, and then glanced toward the tiled changing-room corridor.

"Listen, Jordan," Ryan said warmly, "I know your AAC tablet is locked up in the dry locker right now, and I don't want to make you play charades in the water when I've been wanting to sit down and have a real conversation with you since last night. What do you say we finish rinsing off, get changed into our street clothes so you have your voice back, and meet out in the dry lobby lounge in twenty minutes?"

Jordan stared at Ryan for a full beat in disbelief before nodding so enthusiastically that everyone in the pool laughed.

3:10 PM — Street Clothes, Wheel-to-Wheel & *"Don't You Live in Beverly Hills?!"*

Twenty minutes later, showered and dressed in faded jeans, sneakers, and their worn maroon **`CPI`** alumni sweatshirts, **Ryan**, **Cassidy**, **Holly**, **Evan**, and **Tyler** waited by the sunlit tables of the upper lobby lounge overlooking the natatorium.

When the glass corridor door from the **Family Changing Suites** opened and **Jordan** rolled out in his dry fourteen-pound titanium manual chair (***Shuttlecraft Galileo***, `Vanguard AeroLite-Ti`) wearing a maroon CPI hoodie and jeans—now with his digital behind-the-ear hearing aids in place and his **`mPad`** mounted squarely across his lap—Ryan pushed his matte-black titanium chair across the carpet, spun a smooth 180-degree turn, and parked right beside Jordan's right wheel.

Wheel to wheel. Eye level to eye level.

Ryan could see Jordan looking back and forth between their two manual wheelchairs and Ryan's face, his eyes still wide with the sheer cognitive whiplash of the afternoon—trying to reconcile the stadium guitarist from last night with the forty-eight-year-old guy in a sweatshirt sitting two inches from his push-rims.

Suddenly, Jordan's fingers flew across his **`mPad`** screen, and the crisp Australian female voice of his *EchoType* synthesizer rang out with unguarded nineteen-year-old honesty:

"I still cannot believe you actually waited to talk to me! And wait—I hope this isn't a dumb question, Ryan, but you guys are rich and famous and sold millions of albums all over the world. Don't famous rock stars live in massive mansions in Beverly Hills?! Wait… when your 2004 album is called Progress Street, do you mean THE Progress Street right here in Blacksburg?!"

Ryan threw his head back and roared with laughter, while Cassidy, Holly, Evan, and Tyler lost it completely beside him.

“Beverly Hills?!” Ryan laughed, slapping his armrest as Jordan’s friends grinned around them. “Oh, man, Jordan—that is the best question anybody has asked me in twenty years! I’ll tell you the god’s honest truth: back in 1992, when we were still stuck on **Apex Records** after *Electric Color* and *Neon Hearts*, the label executives *did* rent a massive gated mansion for us out in Beverly Hills while we were out in L.A. cutting our third project, *Friction*—and billed every dime of the lease back to our recoupable advance! And we hated every single minute of it!”

“Every single second!” **Cassidy** agreed fervently, adjusting her dry glasses. “Everything was plastic, the air tasted like eight lanes of freeway smog, the mansion had twenty marble steps at the front door with zero wheelchair ramps so Evan and Tyler had to haul Ryan’s chair up and down the stairs every day, and most of all—it wasn’t Blacksburg. It wasn’t home.”

“And yes,” **Holly** grinned, pointing her thumb north toward Blacksburg, “when we say **Progress Street**, we mean *the* **Progress Street** right here in Blacksburg—two blocks north of **Commonwealth Mall**! That 1900s farmhouse originally belonged to **Aunt Clara Wright**—Evan and Tyler’s mom, and Ryan’s, Cassidy’s, and my maternal aunt. When the guys and Cass started as CPI freshmen in the fall of 1985 and I was only sixteen years old in dual enrollment, Aunt Clara served as our live-in landlord and leased the house to us for one dollar a year so we could legitimately check the ‘Living with a Local Relative’ box on CPI’s housing form and skip the freshman dorms! We started the band in her unheated cinder-block garage out back, fled straight back there from Beverly Hills in 1992, and bought the house outright from Aunt Clara in 1996 to gut-renovate it with a three-stop hydraulic elevator and wraparound ramp.”

“Why on earth would I want to sit in a mansion in Beverly Hills,” Ryan smiled, looking straight across at Jordan from his chair, “when I can live on **Progress Street** with my sisters and my cousins, roll six miles down the **Huckleberry Trail** under the autumn leaves without a single person hassling us, and pay thirty bucks a month for a Town of Christiansburg non-resident pass to soak in a ninety-five-point-five-degree therapy pool?”

Jordan grinned from ear to ear and tapped his screen:

“Okay, that makes total sense. Ninety-five-point-five degrees in The Cove beats Beverly Hills any day. Plus, Beverly Hills doesn’t have Blue Ridge Transit kneeling ramps.”

“Speaking of **Blue Ridge Transit** kneeling ramps!” Ryan said, leaning an elbow on his armrest as the two of them talked shop like veteran manual chair users. “Cass and I were watching the exterior security feed from the production truck at `10:50 PM` last night when you guys boarded the articulated bus at the **Crucible Bus Loop**. Who taught you that 180-degree reverse climb up the steep front bus ramp in your **`Shuttlecraft Galileo`**? Because you backed that titanium frame up a twelve-degree diamond-plate incline in two pulls flat without touching the yellow side curbs once!”

Jordan’s cheeks flushed with pride as his fingers danced across the glass:

“I figured it out on Route 1 last year! If you roll up a steep front bus ramp forward in a manual chair, your center of gravity tips back and you get trapped between the front wheel wells trying to make a three-point turn. If you spin 180 degrees on the sidewalk and pull up backward in reverse, your big rear drive wheels hit the lip first and you glide straight into the securement bay!”

“That is textbook manual-chair physics right there,” Ryan said with a nod of genuine respect, tapping his knuckles against the anodized push-rim of Jordan’s **`Vanguard AeroLite-Ti`**. “When I first got out of Star City General after my T10 spinal cord injury in 1991, it took me six months to figure out reverse ramp boarding without popping a caster.”

For the next thirty-five minutes in the dry upper lobby of the **Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center**, Ryan got the exact unhurried conversation he had wished for when he watched the Blue Ridge Transit shuttle pull away from the Crucible Bus Loop the night before: * With his **`mPad`** right on his lap—and **Aubrie Jean** and **Madison** chiming in effortlessly beside him whenever Jordan got so animated that he gestured and typed at the same time—Jordan told Ryan, Cassidy, Holly, Evan, and Tyler about his 350-pound ***S.S. Freedom*** (`Vanguard Titan-X350`) power chair for steep campus hill climbs, how **Daniel Brooks** had bought both the *S.S. Freedom* and *Shuttlecraft Galileo* so he could send his mother’s old hospital chair to the scrap heap, and how he and Aubrie Jean were getting married on **July 15** with a string quartet playing **“My Anchor Holds”** as their processional. * Cassidy’s eyes misted over behind her glasses when Jordan typed what *“My Anchor Holds”* and *“The Roche Limit”* had meant to him in `Section 104, Row A` the night before, and **Tyler** showed Jordan and Mark photos on his **`mPhone`** of the custom hydraulic wheelchair lift inside **Unit 01 (*The Iron Horse*)** and the 5-second front flip-out ramp on their **Prairie Coachworks RLFD30** low-floor Progress Street shuttle parked right outside in the oversized lot.

When they finally rolled out through the automatic sliding glass doors into the sunny Sunday afternoon at `15:50`, Ryan paused his manual chair beside Jordan’s under the covered entrance canopy and shook Jordan’s hand firmly.

“I am really glad I asked you if that was you from `Section 104`, Jordan,” Ryan smiled. “We swim down here every Tuesday and Thursday afternoon when we’re not tracking in the basement on Progress Street. Next time we pass each other in **The Cove** or out on the **Huckleberry Trail** at five-thirty—now we don’t just have to wave. We’re neighbors.”

“See you on Tuesday or Thursday, Ryan,” Jordan’s **`mPad`** replied warmly as he tapped two fingers to his temple in their signature salute. *“Thank you for waiting to talk to me.”*

> **Companion Perspective (*The Eleventh Child* — Jordan Fuller’s POV):** Read this Sunday afternoon therapy-pool icebreaker and dry-lobby conversation from Jordan’s perspective in **The Eleventh Child — Spring Semester 2016, Part 8: *The Cove (95.5°F): Two Wheelchairs at the Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center*** • Explore the band’s full cosmic archive at **`stardust.raggiesoft.com`**.